NO. 139 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

WEDNESDAY 21 OCTOBER 2026



1,451,579 VOTES TO 477,642, AND THE COUNT IS UNOFFICIAL (P3)

THE WORLD

Alberta votes three to one to stay in Canada, and backs eight of nine other questions

Twelve Desks · One World

THE ATELIER

Tefal advertises 7.7 bar; the iron a tailor buys runs 3.5

THE RABBIT HOLE

The best mushroom app named the death cap right three times in five

Source: a Reuters photograph by Ahmed Zakot, published by Al Jazeera, opened and examined by this desk before captioning — supporters of the pro-Canada group Forever Canadian on Macleod Trail, Calgary, on polling day, 19 October 2026. Cropped; no other alteration.

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NO SPINE TODAY — a straight news book. Three of the week's stories are large and unrelated: a province that voted, a strait nobody can count, and seven companies in a ministerial sentence.

FROM THE DESK

"A nation's existence is a daily plebiscite."

Ernest Renan, *Qu'est-ce qu'une nation?*, lecture at the Sorbonne, 11 March 1882[1]

Renan meant it as an argument against blood and soil: a nation is held together by consent renewed, not by descent. Alberta has just renewed it literally, and in the same breath asked for nine specific things back (p3). The vote is unofficial until the 29th.

THE STRIP · AT TUESDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.79%	▲ 2bp
US 10-year[2]	5.12%	▼ 3bp
VWRA	$191.36	▼ 0.11%
Global agg	$5.76	▲ 0.09%
DXY	101.70	▼ 0.27%
USD/SGD	1.2771	▼ 0.02%
Brent	$109.10	▼ 0.38%
Gold	$4,124.10	▼ 0.38%
Bitcoin	$82,825	▲ 1.10%

The Straits Times Index closed **5,404.02**, down 0.15 per cent (p14). Every level read at source instrument by instrument. Not advice.[2]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · WEDNESDAY

No. 138 held Alberta's result because polls had only just closed and no number could be read. Elections Alberta's own feed has it now, and No. 135's 66–34 poll was wide of it (p3).

No. 136 held September's export print when the agency refused. It is corroborated twice over now at **+68.4 per cent** — but **EnterpriseSG's own page has returned 500 for a third issue**, so it is still not read at the source that published it.

No. 137 called China's open-source carve-out revocable and No. 138 withdrew it. Nothing read this week uses revocation language either; the live ambiguity is how "public domain" gets decided (p7).

No. 136 printed NEA's 2015 investigations as still open. Three of the seven firms served this month were served the same notices in 2015 (p5).

No. 138 put Beam 1.0's smallest build at 103GB. Six days later a community quant halved the problem again at a far bigger model (p8).

SOURCES 1 Ernest Renan delivered *Qu'est-ce qu'une nation?* as a lecture at the Sorbonne on 11 March 1882; the line is given here in the standard English rendering of "l'existence d'une nation est un plébiscite de tous les jours". **The gloss on his argument is this desk's characterisation of the lecture, not a quotation from it.** 2 Levels at Tuesday 20 October's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on p14, with changes against 19 October; **Treasury yields read row by row from the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file. One service put the dollar index at 101.53 in its wrap against 101.70 on its own quote page; the quote page is printed and the discrepancy is disclosed on p14.**

THE WORLD · ALBERTA

Albertans vote 75 to 25 to stay in Canada

Elections Alberta's unofficial count stood at 1,451,579 to 477,642 on Tuesday evening. Only question eight — opting out of federal programmes while keeping the money — failed.

Albertans voted on **Monday 19 October** to remain a province of Canada, by **1,451,579** votes to **477,642** — **75.24 per cent** against **24.76** — on the tenth and last question of a ten-question referendum. The figures are Elections Alberta's own, read off the live feed its dashboard calls, timestamped **21:17 GMT on 20 October** with **4,960** of **5,583** polls in.[1]

Question ten was not a protest line. It asked whether Alberta should begin the legal process toward a binding separation referendum, and the province answered three to one that it should not. Prime Minister **Mark Carney** called it a "great result for Canada"; Premier **Danielle Smith**, who voted against independence, said Albertans had voted "for a stronger Alberta in a united Canada".[2]

The nine other questions ran the other way; eight passed. Proof of citizenship to vote took **63.48 per cent**, the widest margin on the paper; provincial control over immigration **54.12**; a twelve-month residency bar before social supports **57.71**; abolishing the Senate **53.64**; provincial laws prevailing over federal ones **51.36**. The single failure was question eight — opting out of federal programmes while keeping the federal funding — beaten **50.79** to **49.21**.[3]

Two cautions belong beside those numbers, and Elections Alberta supplies both. The count is **unofficial**, with the official result due **Thursday 29 October**; and question ten was counted *first*, so it rests on **1,929,221** ballots while questions one to nine sit on between **1.09** and **1.61** million and were due to finish only today. Turnout has not been published at all — the feed returns null where the field belongs. What is published is the shape of it: **519,082** ballots by mail, roughly ten times the 2023 provincial election.[12]

75.24%

TO REMAIN A PROVINCE OF CANADA — QUESTION TEN, UNOFFICIAL, 4,960 OF 5,583 POLLS[1]

8 of 9

OTHER QUESTIONS CARRIED, FROM IMMIGRATION CONTROL TO ABOLISHING THE SENATE[3]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Reads the vote through Washington rather than Ottawa, setting it beside US Treasury Secretary **Scott Bessent**'s January remark that "I think we should let them come down into the US" and Elon Musk's post that the province "should separate". The story here is annexation pressure failing.[4]

JOHANNESBURG — BUSINESSDAY

Headlines a "boost for Carney" and files it with Quebec's **5 October** election, where an independence-minded party took power but fell short of a majority. It carries the Angus Reid finding of **16 October** that **62 per cent** of Albertans expect the movement never to end.[5]

THE CHATTER · THE LOSING SIDE CONCEDED NOTHING

Jeffrey Rath, co-founder of the Alberta Prosperity Project, at a separatist rally: **"Our movement isn't going anywhere... We're sick and tired of being regulated by Ottawa. We've dominated the conversation in the last year."** The project says it awaits "the release of the official count and a careful analysis of the process". Alberta NDP leader **Naheed Nenshi** was shorter: **"Albertans saved Canada."**[24]

THE SCEPTIC · THREE TO ONE IS NOT THE WHOLE BALLOT

Read question ten alone and the movement lost badly. Read the whole paper and the province endorsed, by margins of **51 to 63 per cent**, most of the powers a separation would have delivered — immigration, the courts, the Senate, residency bars, provincial primacy over federal law. The one thing Albertans refused was the money without the obligation. That is a province rejecting the exit and keeping the bill of complaint.[3]

The union is safe on the day's own evidence and the grievance is intact. The argument that follows will be fought over the nine questions nobody is quoting.

SOURCES 1 **Elections Alberta's own results feed, read directly** — the rendered dashboard returns an empty shell, so the JSON it calls was read at `results.elections.ab.ca/data/8400`; lastUpdated 2026-10-20T21:17:42Z, 4,960 of 5,583 polls, 13,078,024 question-votes recorded, with the Option 1 / Option 2 label mapping confirmed in the dashboard's own script. Advance, election-day, mail and mobile shares from the same feed. 2 Elections Alberta's own site for the 19 October polling date and the 29 October official result; **Global News, read at source**, for the Carney and Smith quotations, the 519,082 mail-in ballots and the ten-fold increase on 2023. 3 Per-question percentages from the same feed; **Global News' independent tally at 81 per cent of voting locations corroborates the shape**, as does a Johannesburg daily's count of eight of nine carried. 4 Al Jazeera, 20 October 2026, read at source, for the Bessent and Musk framings and the Rath remarks. 5 BusinessDay (Johannesburg), 20 October 2026, read at source. **Turnout is published nowhere and is not estimated here.** CNN returned 451 to this desk; both Indian dailies were unreachable.

THE WORLD · HORMUZ

Iran's Revolutionary Guard says its mines set three tankers ablaze south of Hormuz

Brent reached $111.67 on Tuesday, its highest since May. No ship has been named, and Kpler puts Gulf outflows at 8.5m barrels a day against more than 20m a fortnight ago.

The **Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps** said on **Tuesday 20 October** that mines laid by its navy at what it called an "illegal crossing point" in the southern strait had set fire to two "violating" tankers, and later told state television that a third had struck a mine after switching off its radar, carrying "over 2 million barrels of crude oil". **No vessel has been named**, and the third ship appears in one wire account and not the other.[1]

It moved the price. **Brent** traded at **$111.67** on 20 October, up **1.94 per cent** and the highest since May; it was **$109.10** when this desk read it on Wednesday morning. Kpler put average daily oil flows out of the Persian Gulf at **8.5m barrels** earlier in the week, against more than **20m** two weeks before, and counted **at least 18** tanker attacks in the fortnight to 20 October. War-risk cover is quoted at up to **10 per cent** of hull value, from **0.25** before the war.[2]

Two days earlier the Dutch-flagged tug **Jif Barracuda** was hit by two projectiles about **20 nautical miles** north-east of Khor Fakkan. Her AIS had last been seen the previous day: she went dark *before* she was hit, which is what makes counting so hard. The IMO puts the seafarers stranded since February at about **6,000**.[3][4]

TEHRAN — PRESS TV

Headlines the burning ships as "violating" tankers in a "prohibited Hormuz corridor", and reports the Guard saying Iran's "control will endure". The framing is legal, not military. **The article bodies returned 503; only headlines were read.**[5]

RIYADH — ARAB NEWS

Keeps the entire episode inside quotation marks — "Iran Guards *say* three tankers hit mines" — relays Tehran's "violating" and "illegal" wording as Tehran's own, and declines to verify either the mines or the two-million-barrel cargo.[1]

THE CHATTER · THE REGULATOR POINTS AT THE OWNERS

Arsenio Dominguez, secretary-general of the International Maritime Organization, says transits should stop until safety can be assured: **"It is not safe, the negotiations need to take place."** Then the unusual part — he blamed **"irresponsible shipowners that are taking the risk in order to trade"**. The analyst **Tom Bike** counted **11** vessels still running the shuttle in imagery dated 19 October.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A PREMIUM, NOT A SHORTAGE

ING's **Warren Patterson** and **Ewa Manthey**, 19 October: prices "remain well-supported… **despite relatively strong Persian Gulf flows**", which "suggests the market is pricing in a significant risk premium". US Energy Secretary **Chris Wright** puts flows at about **80 per cent** of pre-war. The flow figures do not agree with each other either: **8.5m b/d** out of the Gulf, **13.1m** in late September, **24m** region-wide — three scopes, three numbers, and one of them in every headline.[2][6]

ELSEWHERE

Sudan. A drone strike near a West Kordofan market on the evening of **Sunday 18 October** killed **80** people, among the deadliest single strikes since 2023. The RSF, which holds the state, blamed the army.[7]

Saudi Arabia. The Houthis claim **six** attacks in 48 hours — Yanbu, Shaybah, the Riyadh and Abha airports — answering **200**-plus Saudi strikes on Yemen; Riyadh has postponed its investment conference.[8]

SOURCES 1 AFP via Arab News, 20 October 2026, read at source, for the Guard's statements, the "illegal crossing point" and the two-million-barrel claim; Euronews of the same day, read at source, carries only two tankers. **The third tanker is single-sourced and is printed as Iran's claim.** 2 A Seoul financial daily, read at source, for Brent at $111.67 (+1.94%) on 20 October; oilprice.com, read at source, for the 8.5m b/d Kpler figure via Reuters, the 18 attacks and the earlier $109.68; the oilprice front page for $109.10 on 21 October. **Two WTI prints this week cannot be the same contract, so no WTI level is printed.** 3 Maritime Executive, read at source, for the Jif Barracuda, its AIS history, Mr Bike's count and the IMO quotations; Euronews for the Duqm advisory. **UKMTO's own site returned 403 to this desk from every angle, so No. 138's attack and transit counts are NOT refreshed here.** 4 Al Jazeera's 20 October live file, read at source; Press TV's index for the Qalibaf line. 5 Press TV headlines, 20 October 2026. 6 Al Jazeera, 20 October, for Mr Wright and the flow dispute; The National of the same day for the diesel and sanctioned-fleet figures. **CENTCOM's denial reached this desk only through the outlets carrying it; centcom.mil returned 403.** 7 Democracy Now's 20 October headlines, read at source. 8 Xinhua's 20 October world briefing, read at source.

SINGAPORE · THE HAZE COMPANIES

Shanmugam says Singapore is questioning seven SGX-listed firms over the Indonesian fires

The Senior Minister named bank financing and government grants as levers on 19 October, and said legislation could be amended "on an urgent basis". Twelve years on, no company has been prosecuted.

Senior Minister **K. Shanmugam** said at a doorstop on **Monday 19 October** that the Government is questioning **seven SGX-listed agricultural companies** over possible links to the Indonesian fires behind this month's haze, and will use "every legal and regulatory lever" it has. They are **Golden Agri-Resources, Bumitama Agri, First Resources, Wilmar International, Kencana Agri, Indofood Agri** and **TSH Resources**; **Asia Pulp and Paper** is also being examined.[1]

The levers are the news. He named access to bank financing — MAS supervises the banks — and a review of government grants, and said legislation could be amended "on an urgent basis". Zero-burning pledges are **"not good enough"**, and the companies **"should not underestimate the Singapore government's determination to act"**. **"We will pursue this matter for as long as it takes."**[1]

The market had already moved: after the Prime Minister's post on **Friday 16 October**, First Resources fell as much as **9.1 per cent**, Bumitama Agri **7.5** and Golden Agri-Resources **6.9**. SGX RegCo warned of "appropriate regulatory action" for disclosure failures the same day.[2]

The 2015 thread Nos. 136 to 138 kept open now has an answer. NEA served notices on seven Indonesian firms on 16 October and three more on the 19th, taking the total to **ten** — and **three of the first seven** were served the same notices in **2015**. Those investigations remain open. The Singapore Environment Council has restricted Asia Pulp and Paper's green label, as in 2015.[3]

THE HAZE, THE WORKERS AND THE MASKS

The west is now the worst region, and worsening. NEA's own feed at **05:00 today**: west **134**, central **117**, north **83**. NEA forecasts a 24-hour PSI of **110 to 180** today. **haze.gov.sg was serving "Advisory unavailable" with blank gauges.**[4]

MOM issued a rulebook for outdoor workers on 20 October, keyed to the 1-hour PM2.5 reading rather than the daily forecast. Four bands: Normal 0–55; Elevated 56–150; High 151–250, where N95s must be provided; Very High 251+, where vulnerable staff are barred outdoors and everyone gets **10 to 15 minutes** indoors each hour, and risk assessments must account for visibility **"especially for lifting operations with tower and mobile cranes"**. The west's 81 this morning sits in band two.[6]

IMDA fined Singtel S$1m on 20 October over the March outages that hit about **720,000** subscribers. A vendor left a manual valve shut after maintenance; the chiller failed; the 16 March outage ran over nine hours. IMDA called it preventable and not a cyber-attack.[7]

THE CHATTER · JAKARTA ANSWERS BACK

Muhammad Lutfi, Indonesia's former trade minister, on Instagram on 20 October: Singapore should **"not write warning letters just to make your constituents and voters happy"**, and **"Singapore has no jurisdiction in Indonesia, and you know that"** — urging it to sue the companies' Singapore headquarters instead.[8]

THE SCEPTIC · THE ACT HAS NEVER REACHED A COURTROOM

Prof Alan Tan of NUS, on the root causes: **"not much has changed."** He expects Singapore to wait for Jakarta to name companies first. **Azam Hawari** of ClientEarth says a claimant "would need to show a link between the company's activities, the haze that reached them, and their losses" — and knew of no case ever brought successfully. The problem is in the statute: attribution needs hotspot maps from a foreign authority, and fines are hard to collect from firms with no Singapore presence.[5]

SOURCES 1 A Singapore news site's report of the 19 October doorstop, read at source, for the seven named companies, the two further firms, the levers and every quoted remark; Minister for Sustainability and the Environment Grace Fu also spoke. 2 The Securities Investors Association (Singapore) market wrap, read at source, for the 16 October share moves and SGX RegCo's statement. 3 **NEA's own release page, read at source** (dated 16 October, last updated 19 October), for the ten notices and the named firms; a Singapore news site for the three 2015 repeats and the green-label restriction; phys.org, read at source, for the four 2015 investigations remaining open. 4 **Singapore's own environment data feed, read directly at two endpoints**, for the 21 October 05:00 regional PSI and PM2.5; AsiaOne, read at source, for NEA's overnight 110–180 forecast and the 20 October evening readings. **nea.gov.sg's own PSI pages returned 404 and haze.gov.sg rendered no values.** 5 phys.org, read at source, for Prof Tan, Mr Hawari and the enforcement analysis. 6 **The Ministry of Manpower's own release of 20 October 2026, read at source**, for all four bands and the crane clause. MOH released part of the national N95 stockpile to retailers on 20 October (AsiaOne, read at source). 7 **IMDA's own release dateline of 20 October confirmed at source**; the figures are from a Singapore news site reading the release, because IMDA renders its body in JavaScript. 8 An Indonesian business site, read at source, for Mr Lutfi's posts; a Singapore news site for Mr Dudung.

THE ATELIER · IRONS & STEAM GENERATORS

Tefal advertises 7.7 bar and a tailor's Italian boiler runs 3.5

The IEC's 60311 standard defines how to measure a steam rate and never mentions pressure. The consumer figure is a pump's peak; Reliable's is the working vessel.

The number on the box of a domestic steam generator is a **pump** pressure. The number on the machine a tailor buys is a **boiler** pressure. **Tefal's GV9710** publishes **7.6 bar**; a retail page for the GV9720 says **7.7** in its spec table and **7.3** in the marketing two centimetres above. **Reliable's 4100IS**, built in Italy for sewing rooms at **US$799**, runs **3.5**.[1][2]

No standard polices either figure. **IEC 60311:2016** revised clause **9.2.3** precisely to clarify how a steaming rate is measured — and states in its own scope that it is **"concerned neither with safety nor with performance requirements"**. Pressure appears nowhere in it. The grams per minute has a defined test and no pass mark; the bar has neither.[1]

The hierarchy underneath is metallurgical. **Robert Kahn** of Reliable, writing for the garment trade: a boiler **"should always be stainless steel, never aluminum"**; the base plate is **"always aluminum, never fancy coatings that could easily scratch off"**; and **"the wattage of the iron is almost meaningless by itself"**. Every premium domestic soleplate here is a coating.[3]

And the badge is rented. Philips sold Domestic Appliances to Hillhouse in **2021** with a **15-year brand licence** it valued at about **€0.7bn**. The buyer trades as **Versuni**, whose own small print reads: **"Philips, Saeco, Gaggia and Walita are registered trademarks of Koninklijke Philips N.V."** Braun went the same way in 2012, on a **perpetual** licence to De'Longhi naming **ironing**.[4]

THE LADDER, PRICED

The sweet spot — US$699. Reliable 3000IS: 2.5 bar, a **1.4L all-stainless boiler** you drain and rinse for life, with a stated **lifetime warranty on boiler tanks**.[2]

The grail. Jiffy J-4000, US$380, is the one object here with a published bill of materials: die-cast aluminium shell, **304 stainless** boiler, brass fittings, Tennessee since 1940.[2][5]

Singapore. Mains here is **230V**; most professional kit is 120V. Laurastar prices the compromise in watts — **"2200 W / 1700 W (US only)"** — and **its store finder lists nine countries, none of them Singapore**. Philips/Versuni simply plugs in: **S$668** at Harvey Norman.[5][6]

THE CHATTER · QUILTERS PRESS MORE HOURS THAN TAILORS DO

On QuiltingBoard the Laurastar is lusted after and vindicated on lifespan — **cashs_mom**, September 2025: **"The first one lasted for over 10 years with daily use"**; from 2016, **"Laurastar has me drooling but the PRICE!"** The Oliso cult has apostates — **crzypatcher**, July 2024: two irons, **"they both died at 1 year"**, one with the lifting feet stuck down.[7]

THE SCEPTIC · THE BEST WITNESS SELLS THE EXPENSIVE MACHINE

Robert Kahn owns Reliable, and he writes for the trade that **"Gravity feed irons are nothing more than glorified home irons"** and, of the category, **"Frankly, a $49.00 iron at Wal-Mart will work pretty much as well (sorry, but it is true)."** That is a man arguing against his own industry's spec sheet. The money, he says, belongs in the *table*.[3]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Mosquito nets & bed canopies — the tropical object with a published standard behind it.

Suit & shirt hangers — shoulder flare, cedar, and the item nobody costs properly.

Upholstered sofas & armchairs — eight-way hand-tied springs, and the frame nobody sees.

SOURCES 1 **IEC's own webstore entry for IEC 60311:2016, Edition 5.0, read at source**, for the scope, the 9.2.3 revision and the "neither safety nor performance" line; **Tefal Ireland's own GV9710 product page, read at source**, for 7.6 bar, 155 g/min continuous and the 580 g/min shot; an Australian retailer's GV9720 page, read at source, for the 7.7-against-7.3 contradiction on one screen. 2 **Reliable's own product pages, read at source**, for the 3000IS (US$699, 2.5 bar, 1.4L stainless, Italy), 4100IS (US$799, 3.5 bar), the 270IR (US$229, anodised), the iron heads, the 600VB and the 100SR, and for the lifetime boiler-tank policy. 3 Fashion-Incubator's trade post by Robert Kahn of Reliable, read at source, for every quoted line, and Kathleen Fasanella's commentary on the same page. 4 **Philips' Form 6-K on the SEC's own archive, read at source**, for €3.7bn, €4.4bn, the 15-year licence and the €0.7bn NPV; Philips' completion release for the ~€3bn net proceeds; **Versuni's own brands page** for the trademark line; **De'Longhi's own 16 April 2012 release, downloaded as a PDF and text-extracted**, for the perpetual Braun licence, its naming of ironing, and the €50m/€90m terms. 5 Jiffy Steamer's own pages (J-2000 US$289, J-4000 US$380, 304 stainless, Tennessee since 1940); a US dealer, read at source, for Naomoto HYS-58 and HYS-520; **Laurastar's own Lift manual PDF** for 3.5 bar constant and the 2200/1700W line, and its own store finder for the nine countries. 6 Harvey Norman Singapore's own pages, read at source, for S$668 and S$549 and the 24-month warranties. 7 QuiltingBoard threads of 2015, 2016, 2024 and 2025, read at source and quoted under the handles posted. **Reddit, Styleforum, Permanent Style, PatternReview, Wawak, Morplan and William Gee all refused this desk. Laurastar names no factory anywhere on its own site; the Italian firm that builds Reliable's boilers is named nowhere either.**

TECHNOLOGY · AMERICAN MANUFACTURING

Apple commits US$100m to a Pennsylvania titanium mill for the iPhone Duo case

The 20 October release claims nearly 100 components from US firms. Assembly stays in China and India, and JPMorgan has just cut Duo shipments to 8–9 million units.

Apple said on **Tuesday 20 October** that it will commit **up to US$100 million over three years** to the **Perryman Company** of Houston, Pennsylvania, which melts, forges and rolls the grade-5 titanium for the iPhone Duo enclosure. The same release names **Broadcom**, modernising its Fort Collins fab under a **US$1.5bn** commitment to make **more than 15 billion** US chips for Apple, and **TSMC**'s Arizona fab, making **more than 100 million** in 2026.[1]

The claim to read carefully is the headline one: **nearly 100 components** in the iPhone Duo and iPhone 18 Pro come from US firms. By **end-2026**, Corning's Harrodsburg plant will supply **all** iPhone and Apple Watch cover glass sold worldwide, and Coherent in Sherman, Texas makes the Face ID emitters. Apple puts the whole programme inside a **US$600bn**, four-year US commitment.[1]

Beijing moved the same week, and in two different registers. Export controls on **full-face tunnel boring machines**, climbing excavators and plateau shotcrete machines were confirmed by MOFCOM and Customs on **19 October**, effective **18 November**, with a two-tier licence: a State Council licence for **"sensitive countries and regions with which China has disputes"** and registration filing elsewhere. The AI list remains a *draft*: Announcement No. 48 proposes **40** technologies — 23 AI, 12 photovoltaic, 5 biomedicine; 14 prohibited and 26 restricted — and consultation closes **15 November**.[2][3]

No. 137's "revocable" open-source carve-out stays corrected. The proposed language is exemption and facilitation: technologies already in the public domain through open-source release or academic publication are proposed for exclusion, and open-sourcing is listed among the scenarios receiving facilitated licensing. What the drafts do not explain is how "public domain" status will be determined — which is the live ambiguity, not revocation. Taipei said on **16 October** it will add advanced semiconductors and AI servers to its own control list, making unauthorised shipment to China a criminal offence; in August nine people were indicted over an alleged scheme to export **130** AI servers.[3][4]

US$100m

APPLE'S THREE-YEAR COMMITMENT TO ONE PENNSYLVANIA TITANIUM PRODUCER[1]

18 Nov

BORING MACHINES BECOME LICENSABLE; THE AI LIST IS STILL ONLY A DRAFT TO 15 NOVEMBER[2]

THE CHATTER · SPECIALISTS READ IT, NOBODY ELSE DOES

Hacker News carried China's draft **eight separate times** between 16 and 19 October and not one submission caught: the best was "China to Restrict Open-Weights Model Exports" at **13 points and 3 comments**. Apple's HomeView page the same week drew **760 points and 920 comments** (p9). The most-submitted framing of the Chinese draft was the open-weights angle, not the chips.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · NINETY-NINE PARTS IS NOT A PHONE

Justin Scharlemann, Tech Between The Lines, 20 October: **"That is not the same claim as 100 parts made on American soil, and a phone like the Duo has well over 100 parts."** And: **"iPhones are still assembled in China and India, and nothing in this announcement changes that."** On Apple's Houston plant, which builds Mac mini, he notes it **"has never been willing to do that for the product that sells in the hundreds of millions"**. The timing compounds it: JPMorgan cut its 2026 iPhone Duo forecast to about **8–9 million** units from around 10 million on supply constraints — a titanium announcement landing while the titanium-bodied phone is short.[6]

SOURCES 1 **Apple's own newsroom release of 20 October 2026, read at source**, for the Perryman commitment, the recycled-titanium figure, Broadcom, TSMC Arizona, Amkor, Coherent, Corning and the "nearly 100 components" and US$600bn framings. 2 **Global Times, 19 October 2026, read at source**, for the confirmed dual-use additions, the 18 November date, the machine definitions and the two-tier licence. **It does not mention dredgers, so No. 138's dredger line is not repeated here.** 3 Two independent reposts of MOFCOM and MOST Announcement No. 48, read at source, for the 40 technologies, the 14/26 split and the 15 November deadline; **the ministry's own site returned 503 and the reposts garble the numeric thresholds, so no parameter or FLOP threshold is printed**. A third substack reading, read at source, for the exemption-and-facilitation language and the unexplained "public domain" test. 4 Taiwan News, 16 October 2026, read at source, for Minister Kung Ming-hsin's announcement and the August indictment. 5 The Hacker News search index, read at source, for the submission counts and scores. 6 Tech Between The Lines, 20 October 2026, read at source; TipRanks of the same day for the JPMorgan cut, whose analyst the outlet does not name. **Digitimes blocked this desk's address, SCMP returned 403 and The Verge refused.**

THE HOME LAB · MUSE SPARK OPEN

Unsloth squeezes Meta's 816-billion-parameter Muse Spark Open into 176 gigabytes

Meta shipped BF16 and NVFP4 only, and set a 700GB floor. The community had a one-bit quant inside a day — and nobody has published a tokens-per-second figure for it.

Meta released **Muse Spark Open** on **15 October**: **816 billion** total parameters, **42 billion** active, **256** experts with eight routed per token, a one-million-token context, and text, image, video and audio in. Meta ships two precisions only, and states the floors: **at least 700GB of VRAM** for NVFP4, **2TB** for BF16. That is not a home-lab model.[1]

Within a day it was. **Unsloth**'s UD-IQ1_S quant is five shards totalling about **175.6GB** — the first frontier-class open-weights model that fits a single **256GB** Mac Studio at all, against No. 138's Beam 1.0 at 103GB. The official ggml-org Q2_K runs **304GB** and its BF16 **1,640GB**.[2]

The catch is in Unsloth's own guidance. It puts 1-bit at **180–212GB** and 2-bit at **250–316GB** of combined memory, and says UD-IQ2_XXS "will fit on 256GB RAM" — at the very bottom of the band, with almost no headroom for context. And **no tokens-per-second figure has been published for either quant on that machine**. The only measured numbers come from Apple's own MLX benchmark: **15.74 tok/s** on two M5 Ultras pipelined, **24.99** on two tensor-parallel, **36.73** on four. Both companies sold this as a Mac Studio model; on Apple's own data it is a four-Mac-Studio model.[3]

Support landed fast, and the quantisation detail is the interesting part. llama.cpp PR **#30616** merged on **15 October**; its author keeps the latent projections and the attention gate at **Q8_0** — about **1 per cent** of weights — because without that **"the low-bit types turned the output into a repeating loop"**. Separately, build **b11755** on **20 October** fixed a missing Metal kernel for nine experts per token: a Mac MoE path was broken until yesterday.[4]

ALSO ON THE BENCH

llama.cpp merged `--connect` on 19 October: a peer-to-peer WebRTC tunnel from the web UI to llama-server with **"no centralized server"** — remote access to your own rig with no port forward. Experimental, and its author notes **"90% of the code is AI-generated"**.[5]

The 512GB Mac Studio tier Apple promised for "late October" is still not orderable — the configuration both Apple's benchmark and Meta's two-Mac claim depend on. M5 Ultra starts at **S$7,999** here.[6]

THE CHATTER · THE ARITHMETIC NOBODY PUT IN THE PRESS RELEASE

On Hacker News, **petu** does the sum: BF16 needs **"more than 1.6TB of RAM"**, NVFP4 about **493GB**, and streaming weights over PCIe 5.0 at 64 GB/s means **"you should expect roughly 5 tok/s"**. **fluidcruft** prices the GPU route at about ten RTX 5080s, roughly **$15,000**; **bensyverson** notes the 256GB Mac Studio starts at **$9,499**. The most useful datapoint for this bench is **liuliu**'s: a single 256GiB M5 Ultra runs DeepSeek 4.1 Flash at about **45 tok/s** generation.[7]

THE SCEPTIC · SLOWER, AND BENCHMARKED AGAINST ITSELF

AustinDev benchmarked Muse Spark Open against GLM 5.3 Flash locally and found it slower on time-to-first-token, slower on tokens per second, worse under concurrency and lower-scoring; **a11r** backs that with Artificial Analysis showing Muse under both Qwen 3.8 Flash Next and GLM 5.3 Flash. On method, **peri-cl** objects that Apple ran Muse at 4-bit NVFP4 while showing Qwen only at BF16 — **dannyw**'s rebuttal in-thread is that the tables do list the quantisations. And **mrboatshoepants** notes the headline figures use an **8,192-token** context: **"Thats not nearly enough context to be useful these days."**[7]

SOURCES 1 **The Muse Spark Open model card on Hugging Face, read at source**, for the architecture, the expert count, the context length, the precisions shipped and the stated VRAM floors. 2 **The Unsloth and ggml-org GGUF repositories, read at source and summed shard by shard**, for 175.6GB, 304.3GB, 1,640GB and the 2.46TB repo total; the llama.cpp merge thread for Unsloth's own 163.6 GiB. 3 **Unsloth's own model documentation, read at source**, for the per-bit memory bands and the UD-IQ2_XXS claim; **Apple's own machine-learning research post of 15 October 2026, read at source**, for every tok/s and time-to-first-token figure, the RDMA-over-Thunderbolt setup and the ~493GB NVFP4 parameter footprint. **Apple's tables do not state which context each figure belongs to; generation length was 128 tokens.** 4 **llama.cpp PR #30616 and the project's own releases page, read at source**, for the merge, the Q8_0 carve-out, the quoted line, the cosine figures and build b11755. 5 **llama.cpp PR #28277, read at source**, for the tunnel, the quoted lines and the review findings. 6 A Singapore hardware title, read at source, for the M5 Ultra pricing; Engadget's M5 Ultra review for the unavailable 512GB tier. 7 Hacker News threads 50107379 and 50118320, read at source and quoted under the handles posted. **Reddit refused this desk for a seventh consecutive issue, so r/LocalLLaMA is absent again.**

THE KIT · APPLE HOMEVIEW

Apple prices HomeView at S$399 in Singapore; the wall model drops the woofer

Pre-orders opened 15 October and stock ships 13 November. Both versions cost the same, and the wall mount Apple does not include starts at US$59.95.

Apple opened Singapore pre-orders for **HomeView** at **9am on 15 October** and will ship on **Friday 13 November**. Apple's own Singapore store lists both versions at **S$399.00**, limit two each. The US price is **US$299**. It is a **7-inch** Liquid Retina panel on an A18, dimming from **500 nits** to **0.3**, with a 12MP Center Stage camera and recognition of up to six faces.[1]

The buying decision is settled by one component. The tabletop carries two full-range drivers in the display plus a **down-firing woofer and two passive radiators in the base**. The wall-mounted model has no base, so it has no woofer — and Apple does not include the mount, which starts at **US$59.95** for the USB-C connector, **US$79.95** AC-wired and **US$129.95** for Power over Ethernet in early 2027. The wall build therefore costs more than the tabletop and sounds worse.[1][2]

Two hands-on verdicts, neither scored. **Raymond Wong** of Gizmodo: **"But is it $299 cool? That depends on whether you own a home to really make full use of the HomeView."** He found the cable only **1.5m**, no USB-C port under the wall version, and — against the rumours — a screen that tilts by hand and does **not** swivel. **Britta O'Boyle** of Macworld: **"$299 feels fair if you live in Apple's world"** — but the square screen letterboxes video, there is no physical privacy switch, and it cannot act as a security camera.[2][3]

S$399

BOTH HOMEVIEW MODELS IN SINGAPORE — ONE OF WHICH HAS NO WOOFER AND NO MOUNT[1]

ALSO THIS WEEK

Apple TV 4K, fourth generation, S$399 in Singapore: an A19 with up to 50 per cent faster CPU and twice the GPU, a dedicated AV1 decoder, three far-field microphones, and a Siri Remote that now does Find My with Precision Finding. In store **13 November**.[4]

Pre-orders are already slipping. By 15 October Apple TV 4K was quoting **23–27 November** in the US and HomeView in silver and starlight **20 November**, while other colours still showed the 13th.[5]

The week's one scored review: the Xiaomi 18 Fold, 88 per cent at Notebookcheck on 19 October — **26 hours** in the Wi-Fi test, 67W charging to half in 18 minutes; against no eSIM and poor speakers. **China-only**, so no Singapore price exists.[6]

THE CHATTER · THE MOUNT IS THE BARRIER, NOT THE PRICE

The Hacker News thread ran to **760 points and 920 comments**. **nfw2** makes the buy-once point exactly: hunting for third-party mounts and 3D-printed stands is a bigger barrier for ordinary buyers than people expect. **The-Bus** sets the market — a Google Nest Hub is $99 and Meta's Portals launched at $199–349, so $299 is in range. **TheOtherHobbes** argues 7 inches is simply too small for elderly users who need large text, and **tpurves** says an old iPad under the kitchen cabinets already does music and recipes.[7]

THE SCEPTIC · GRUBER GOES AFTER THE LAUNCH FILM

John Gruber, 17 October: **"You need to think you want it if you're going to buy it."** On the advertisement: **"This family's convenient hole in the center of their island countertop is a fantasy"** — the thing must be tethered to USB power, and Apple hides the cable. On the pricing he calls it simply illogical that the wall version costs the same as the model that includes a subwoofer. And the wait-one-generation case is researched: **Mark Gurman** reports a successor codenamed **J595** with a roughly **9-inch** screen, a motorised arm giving full 360-degree swivel and speaker-aware voice recognition, for 2027 or 2028 — and explicitly not at $299.[8]

SOURCES 1 **Apple's own newsroom release of 13 October 2026 and its Singapore store page, both read at source**, for S$399, US$299, the colours, the purchase limit, the 15 October Singapore pre-order, the 13 November on-sale date, the display, the A18, the camera, the microphones, the six-face recognition and the acoustic layout. 2 The same release for the Schneider Home mount prices and the absence of a mount in the box; Macworld, read at source, for the wall model's missing speaker base. 3 Gizmodo's hands-on of 13 October 2026 and Macworld's of 15 October, both read at source, for every quoted verdict, the 1.5m cable, the missing port and the tilt-not-swivel finding. **Neither outlet scored the device.** 4 **Apple's own newsroom releases and Singapore store pages, read at source**, for Apple TV 4K and HomePod mini 2. 5 9to5Mac, 15 October 2026, read at source. 6 Notebookcheck's Xiaomi 18 Fold review, rating and screenshots dated 19 October 2026, read at source. **That page contradicts itself on peak brightness, so no nits figure is printed.** 7 Hacker News thread 50071017, read at source, quoted under the handles posted. 8 **Daring Fireball, 17 October 2026, read at source**; 9to5Mac of 18 October reporting Mark Gurman's Power On newsletter, which is the single primary source for J595.

THE GOOD LIFE · RESSENCE TYPE 10

Ressence's Type 10 DN runs its first in-house calibre, at CHF 45,000

Unveiled at WatchTime New York on 16 October in 100 pieces, deliveries from November. The brand's own site already marks it sold out, at €60,000.

The Antwerp independent **Ressence** unveiled the **Type 10 DN "Dark Night"** at WatchTime New York on **Friday 16 October**: **CHF 45,000** excluding taxes, **100** numbered pieces, deliveries from **November**. It is the first oil-filled Ressence to run on a calibre of its own. The brand's own product page prices it at **€60,000** and already marks it **sold out**, without publishing a piece count.[1]

The mechanism is the story. Calibre **RW-04** is self-winding on an annular rotor with **twin barrels**, a **60-hour** reserve — twenty-four hours more than the Type 3 — at 4Hz, **252** components and **47** jewels. The whole watch runs to **538** parts, of which **196** sit inside the oil-filled ROCS 10 module, separated from the air-side movement by a titanium membrane **0.1mm** thick. Drive across that membrane is magnetic, so the case has **no crown**: it is wound and set from the back. The dial carries an oil-temperature gauge meant to read between **10 and 25°C**.[1][2]

The case is **41.5mm** grade-5 titanium under dark-blue hard DLC, **82g** on its integrated rubber strap, rated **50m**. **Nobody has published a case height** — not Ressence, and not one of the four outlets that covered the launch, one of which simply prints "Unknown". The same outlet caught two errors in the brand's own press sheet: a "75mm" dial inside a 41.5mm case, which it reads as a radius of curvature, and a jewel count that disagrees with the engraving on the rotor.[2]

196 of 538

COMPONENTS SUBMERGED IN OIL, BEHIND A TITANIUM MEMBRANE ONE TENTH OF A MILLIMETRE THICK[1]

"A reasonable value proposition by the standards of other Ressence models" — the extra power reserve arrives at no extra cost.

ALSO ON THE SHELF

Renaud Tixier lifted the embargo on the Monday Skeleton on 20 October: **CHF 129,000** before taxes, **15 pieces each** in petrol blue and green. Calibre RVI2025 is a micro-rotor automatic with the house "dancer" mechanism — 2.5Hz, **72-hour** minimum reserve, **262** components and **238** inward angles, with a platinum micro-rotor. The case is **40.8mm** 18ct grey gold. That is **CHF 50,000** above the standard grey-gold Monday.[3]

Five audio launches landed inside the week — NAD's C 359S amplifier and C 569 CD player, an Audiolab phono stage, the Goldmund Mimesis pre-amp, Triangle standmounts and Jamo's HYG 5 — but **every article body refused this desk**, so not one price or driver spec could be read at source. They are listed, not reviewed.[4]

THE CHATTER · THE VALUE ARGUMENT, FROM A SCEPTICAL QUARTER

Jack Shepherdson of Watches by SJX makes the case that the Type 10 is **"a reasonable value proposition by the standards of other Ressence models"**, because the proprietary movement's extra power reserve is **"effectively offered at no additional cost"**. Founder **Benoît Mintiens** on the design: **"It should feel as if it is one seamless object"**, and on inherited form, **"The first cars were essentially carriages with engines added to them."**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · FOUR OUTLETS, NO WRIST

The only published criticism from a named writer is Shepherdson's own, on legibility: **"There are no numerals to be found, not even on the 24-hour sub-dial for the second time zone... This complicates legibility."** Everything else is launch coverage. **Four outlets covered this watch and not one has handled it**; Fratello's writer says plainly that he **"can't wait to get my hands on"** it. Reliability doubts about the oil-filled platform circulate only in a comment thread, which is not evidence; Ressence's counter is that every oil-filled watch is tested an hour at 60°C and an hour at minus five. Held until someone has worn one.[2]

SOURCES 1 **Ressence's own Type 10 product page, read at source**, for the €60,000 price, the sold-out marking, the case, the membrane and the component counts; four watch titles — Watches by SJX, Fratello, Monochrome and Deployant, all read at source — independently confirm CHF 45,000 and 100 pieces. 2 Deployant, 16 October 2026, read at source, for the WatchTime New York venue and date, the RW-04 specification, Mr Mintiens' quoted remarks and the two press-sheet errors; Watches by SJX, 16 October, read at source, for the value argument, the legibility criticism and the unpublished case height; Fratello of the same day for its writer's stated position. **The venue is single-sourced to Deployant.** 3 Deployant, 20 October 2026, read at source. **Single-sourced.** 4 What Hi-Fi's news index, read at source, for the five dated launches; **every one of those article bodies returned navigation only, so no figure from them is printed here**. Prices seen in search summaries for other audio products this week were not read at source and are omitted.

SCREEN & SOUND · YOU CAN SEE EVERYTHING

A24's Elizabeth Holmes film takes $18,247 a screen on 855 screens

Nathan Fielder and Lance Oppenheim's documentary opened on 16 October to $15.6m and a Metascore of 97 from 40 reviews. Theranos whistleblower Tyler Shultz says it is not a documentary at all.

You Can See Everything, directed by **Nathan Fielder** and **Lance Oppenheim** for A24, opened on **Friday 16 October** and took **$15,601,418** from **855** theatres over the weekend — a per-screen average of **$18,247**, second on the chart. The film that beat it, **Street Fighter**, took **$30,775,377** from **3,575** theatres, which is **$8,608** a screen. Fielder and Oppenheim did more than twice the business per room on less than a quarter of the rooms.[1]

The reviews are close to unanimous. Metacritic has it at **97** from **40** critics — **39 positive, one mixed, none negative** — and Rotten Tomatoes at **98 per cent** from **141**. **Nick Schager** of The Daily Beast scored it 100: **"Not just the film of the year."** The premise: **34 days** before she went to prison, Holmes invited a sceptical crew to film her, and the shoot became a **three-year** project.[2]

The dissent that matters is not a critic's. **Tyler Shultz**, the Theranos whistleblower, wrote in STAT on **19 October**: **"What it certainly is not is a documentary, and it's dangerous to pretend that it is."** His proposed title is **"You Can See Everything That We Chose To Point The Camera At"**. On the device at the centre of the film: **"The device she showed Fielder on the kitchen table was not the reason she went to prison"** — a future version never completed, while the Edison actually used **"could only run one blood test at a time"** and was, he says, an eight-channel pipette inside a black box. He notes Theranos claimed **$108 million** of 2014 revenue against little more than **$100,000** recorded, and that Holmes was filmed in a rented condo having lived in an estate once listed at **$125m**.[3]

$18,247

PER SCREEN, AGAINST STREET FIGHTER'S $8,608 ON FOUR TIMES THE THEATRES[1]

ON THE CHARTS

Jamie T goes straight in at No. 1 on the UK Official Albums Chart for **16–22 October** with GHOSTS (100 DAYS OF MORNING); Chase & Status new at **2** with GENERIC EVERYTHING and Troye Sivan new at **9**. **No units figure is published on the chart and none is printed here.**[4]

The 16 October album Metascores: Richard Thompson's *Hippies, Thugs And Heroes* **95**; Dummy's *Do You Love The Color Of The Sky?* **87**; *Autosmile* by @ **83**; The Avalanches' *No Bad Memories* **82**; Eels' *Cookie Happened* **81**. **Metacritic's individual album pages refused this desk, so no review counts accompany those scores.**[5]

A copy-desk note. A24's own page gives the runtime as **2h55m**; Metacritic and Rotten Tomatoes both say **2h54m**.[2]

THE CHATTER · THE ETHICS QUESTION, ASKED AND ANSWERED

Adam Nayman in The Ringer calls it **"absorbing and entertaining and occasionally beautiful"** and also **"a torture chamber equipped with ropes for hanging"**. On whether Fielder is punching down, he says the question is **"always worth asking"**, then answers it: **"She's a household name under a form of house arrest: What more can Nathan do to harm her reputation?" Alison Willmore** calls it **"a metanarrative mille-feuille about all the ways we try to gauge the truth"**.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · THE ONE MIXED REVIEW IN FORTY

Stephanie Zacharek of TIME is the single non-rave, at **60**: **"Their movie feels more like a product they've brought to market than an example of the documentarian's art"**, and **"This is a dense picture—there's almost too much to unpack."** Shultz, who has more standing than any reviewer, puts the same objection commercially — Holmes led Fielder **"down this BS semantic rabbit hole"** — before conceding the ambiguity the film trades in: **"So, is he a very bad documentarian or a very good artist?"**[35]

SOURCES 1 **Box Office Mojo's weekend 42 chart, read at source**, for both grosses, both theatre counts and both averages; The Numbers' chart for the same weekend, read at source, confirms the figures to the dollar. 2 **Metacritic's film page and critic-review page, and Rotten Tomatoes, all read at source**, for 97 from 40, the 39/1/0 split and 98 per cent from 141; **A24's own film page, read at source**, for the directors, the release date, the 34 days, the three-year shoot and the runtime discrepancy. 3 **STAT First Opinion, 19 October 2026, read at source**, for every Tyler Shultz quotation and the revenue, estate and conviction figures. 4 **The Official Charts albums chart for 16–22 October, read at source.** 5 Metacritic's new-releases browse page, read at source, for the album scores; TIME's score and quotations via Metacritic's critic page and Rotten Tomatoes. 6 The Ringer, 16 October 2026, read at source; Vulture via Metacritic's critic page. **Billboard redirects to a paywall host that returns 402 to this desk, so there is no US chart position or units figure in this issue; Variety and Deadline both redirect to paywall hosts, so there is no CinemaScore, no exit polling and no budget.**

THE FAMILY DESK · SOCIAL MEDIA AND MOOD

A *Pediatrics* study finds no link to anxiety across five waves

The ABCD cohort followed 11,279 adolescents from a mean age of 12.01. Depression ran both ways in two of four intervals; anxiety showed nothing at all.

Pediatrics published **Nagata and colleagues** online on **Monday 19 October**: five annual waves of the ABCD study, **11,279** adolescents, mean age **12.01** at entry, **47.6 per cent** female, analysed with random-intercept cross-lagged panel models. Problematic social media use and depressive symptoms predicted each other **in both directions** at years three-to-four and four-to-five — and showed **no significant association** at two-to-three or five-to-six. With anxiety there was **no significant lagged association in any interval**. The depressive link was stronger and more consistently bidirectional in girls.[1]

That cohort is the reader's. A twelve-year-old at entry is exactly the band the alarm literature usually generalises past, and the finding is a null inside the alarm literature, from the researchers doing the worrying. One honest limitation: **the published abstract reports no betas or confidence intervals for the cross-lagged paths**, and the journal's own site refused this desk, so no effect size is printed.[1]

A second paper the same month points at the behaviour rather than the device. **Bakour and colleagues**, in *Sleep Health* on **10 October**, surveyed **1,510** Florida adolescents aged **11 to 13** and found that simply *owning* a smartphone was associated with **lower** odds of insufficient sleep and of trouble sleeping. What predicted worse sleep was use: the phone in bed, public posting, **more than two hours** of evening use, and cyberbullying — with in-bed use the strongest, at adjusted odds of trouble sleeping **up to 13**. The authors' own summary is that **"how smartphones are used, rather than merely owning one, has substantial implications for sleep"**.[2]

1,510

FLORIDA 11-TO-13S, AMONG WHOM OWNING A PHONE MEANT *LOWER* ODDS OF POOR SLEEP[2]

11,279

ADOLESCENTS, FIVE WAVES, AND NOT ONE SIGNIFICANT LAGGED LINK TO ANXIETY[1]

13×

ADJUSTED ODDS OF TROUBLE SLEEPING AT THE CEILING, FOR IN-BED PHONE USE AMONG 11–13S[2]

THE CHATTER · TWO JOURNALS, ONE AUTHOR, ONE DAY

Dimitri A. Christakis appears on the author list of both 19 October papers — the *Pediatrics* social-media study above and the JAMA *Pediatrics* sleep study on p13 — published the same day in the two leading American paediatrics journals. One reports a null on anxiety; the other measures the mechanism in minutes. Read together they are an argument about where to put parental effort, and it is not on ownership.[13]

THE SCEPTIC · A FINN WHO FOUND THE OPPOSITE

Petri Jalanko, doctoral researcher at the University of Jyväskylä, led a Finnish cohort recruited at ages six to nine and tested at fifteen to seventeen, and found *more* childhood screen time associated with **slightly better** adolescent working-memory reaction time. He is careful in both directions: **"the observed associations were small"**; **"families shouldn't view screen time as automatically harmful in all cases"**; and **"This does not mean that 'more screen time makes teens smarter'."** His explanation for why it stood out: **"public discussion often assumes screen time is uniformly harmful". His paper is dated 17 September, a month before this window.**[4]

General guidance, not medical advice. The practical reading of both papers is narrower than the debate: the hour and the location matter most.

SOURCES 1 Nagata JM, Otmar CD, Li EJ and colleagues, "Problematic Social Media Use and Depressive and Anxiety Symptoms in Adolescents," *Pediatrics*, online 19 October 2026, doi:10.1542/peds.2025-075060 — **abstract read in full at source through the National Library of Medicine's own interface** and cross-checked on Europe PMC, for the sample, the mean age, the sex split, the model and the pattern of significance. **The publisher's own site returned 403, and the abstract carries no coefficients, so none are printed.** 2 Bakour C, Andreadakis J, Flanigan C and colleagues, "Smartphones, digital media use, and sleep in young adolescents," *Sleep Health*, online 10 October 2026, doi:10.1016/j.sleh.2026.09.012 — abstract read at source through the same interface and Europe PMC. **ScienceDirect returned 403, so the individual confidence intervals behind the "up to 13" ceiling were not verified.** The survey is the 2024 Life in Media Survey, fielded 12 November to 9 December 2024. 3 See p13. 4 PsyPost's report of the Finnish PANIC study, read at source, for every Jalanko quotation; the study is published in *Pediatric Exercise Science*. **Dated 17 September 2026. No Singapore item on this subject exists inside 15–21 October: MOE's enhanced screen-use measures date to 30 November 2025 and the CNA–IPS screen-hours survey to January 2025, both confirmed at source, and neither is printed as current.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE SECONDARY TRANSITION

Brittain and Vaillancourt find the move to secondary school bends the anxiety curve

701 Canadian youth followed from Grade 5 to Grade 12. One in ten sat on a rising trajectory, and that class carried more risk in early adulthood than the moderate one.

Heather Brittain and **Tracy Vaillancourt** published in *Development and Psychopathology* on **15 October** a study of **701** Canadian young people, **52.9 per cent** girls, followed from **Grade 5 to Grade 12**. Internalizing symptoms — the anxiety-and-low-mood cluster — showed a significant shift in **both level and growth rate** at the move to secondary school. The transition is not a background condition in their data; it is a hinge.[1]

They found four trajectories. **Low, 51.8 per cent**; **Moderate, 32.5**; **Increasing, 10.6**; **Declining, 5.1**. The finding that should change a parent's attention is this: the **Increasing** class carried **higher early-adulthood risk than the Moderate class** — so the child to watch is not the one with the highest symptoms at any single reading, but the one whose line is *tilting*. Higher symptoms and steeper growth were predicted by being a girl, by lower household income, by **more bullying victimisation**, and by less social support. Three of those four are not fixed.[1]

The mechanism study arrived four days later, and it is unusually clean because nothing was self-reported. **Zhao, Hale and Christakis** in *JAMA Pediatrics* on **19 October** used **passively sensed** phone logs against Fitbit data: **425** adolescents, **7,591 person-nights**, mean age **14.8**. Each additional minute of phone use after 10pm, measured against that adolescent's own average, pushed sleep onset **0.87 minutes** later (95% CI 0.84 to 0.90), sleep offset **0.37** later, and total sleep **0.43 minutes** shorter (CI −0.47 to −0.39). The effect grew steadily from an 8pm cutoff to midnight. On nights with above-average post-10pm use, they slept **20.05 minutes** less and fell asleep **64.73 minutes** later.[2]

Put the two together and the practical reading is narrow. The Canadian data says the risk shows up as a change of slope at a known moment in the calendar — the first term of secondary school — and names bullying victimisation and social support as the levers. The American data says the mechanism runs through sleep, and prices it in minutes. Neither is a licence for a rule about devices; both point at the same fortnight of the year.

10.6%

ON A RISING TRAJECTORY — AND CARRYING MORE ADULT RISK THAN THE MODERATE GROUP[1]

0.43 min

OF SLEEP LOST PER EXTRA MINUTE OF PHONE USE AFTER TEN O'CLOCK, ACROSS 7,591 NIGHTS[2]

THE CHATTER · THE LAST FIVE MINUTES ARE THE ONES THAT COUNT

The same JAMA paper isolates something practical: phone use in the **final five minutes** before sleep onset added **0.74 minutes** (CI 0.50 to 0.98) of sustained wakefulness after falling asleep, concentrated in the first half-hour — and the effect was **negligible** by the final twenty minutes. Twenty minutes of distance between the phone and the pillow is not a slogan in this data; it is roughly where the measured effect disappears.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE COHORT IS NEARLY FIFTEEN, NOT TWELVE

Read the JAMA figures with the age attached. Its mean age is **14.8**, so a twelve-year-old sits at the lower tail of the distribution, not in its centre — the study is the mechanism, not the age-matched finding, and this desk prints it as such. The Canadian trajectory study is the age-matched one, and it is a **single Canadian cohort** of 701 with no replication cited. Neither paper licenses a rule; together they license an hour.[1][2]

General guidance, not medical advice. Of the four predictors in the Canadian data, the one a household can act on fastest is bullying victimisation — and the one it can act on tonight is the twenty minutes before sleep.

SOURCES 1 Brittain H and Vaillancourt T, "The secondary school transition as a turning point for internalizing symptoms," *Development and Psychopathology*, online 15 October 2026, pp.1–13, doi:10.1017/S095457942610203X — **abstract read in full at source through the National Library of Medicine's own interface**, for the sample, the sex split, the grade span, the four latent classes and their percentages, the early-adulthood comparison and the four predictors. 2 Zhao Y, Hale L and Christakis DA, "Evening Phone Use and Sleep Outcomes Among Youth," *JAMA Pediatrics*, online 19 October 2026, doi:10.1001/jamapediatrics.2026.4902 — **read at source on the journal's own page, including its Key Points box**, for the design, the 425 Android users, the 7,591 person-nights, the mean age, every coefficient and confidence interval, the final-five-minutes finding and the descriptive 20.05 and 64.73-minute figures. Data were collected 30 November 2020 to 5 February 2024.

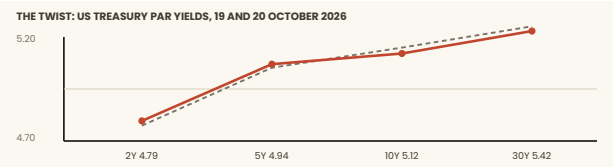
THE MACRO DESK · THE TWIST FLATTENER

Brent fell 2.3 per cent on an unconfirmed Qatar plan

The 2s10s spread closed at +33bp on 20 October, from +38. Equities and bonds came apart again: BNDW up 0.18 per cent, VWRA down 0.11.

The week sits inside the Federal Reserve's pre-meeting blackout, **17 to 29 October**, so nothing moved off a central banker. The driver was the oil tape, and on **Tuesday 20 October** it ran the inflation channel *backwards* for the first time in three issues. An unconfirmed report of a Qatari–Pakistani middle-ground plan put to Washington and Tehran — **US$6 billion** of frozen Iranian funds released — knocked **Brent down 2.3 per cent to $106.99**, settling near **$108.92**.[1]

That mattered because September US CPI printed **3.7 per cent** on 14 October, the energy line doing most of the damage. Cheaper crude takes the inflation tail out of the long end, and the curve showed it precisely: the **ten-year fell 3bp to 5.12 per cent** while the **two-year rose 2bp to 4.79**, collapsing the 2s10s from **+38bp to +33**. That is not the bull flattener of the last three issues but a **twist**: the front end pricing a Fed that still has to hike, the long end an oil shock that might end. CME FedWatch had **83 per cent** on a hold on 27–28 October, **94** on a December hike.[2][3]



A Meridian figure, from the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file.[2]

The decisive detail is that the two legs came apart again, in the useful direction. Where No. 138 had equities and bonds falling together, Tuesday had **BNDW +0.18 per cent** and **AGGU +0.09** rising while **VWRA slipped 0.11**. Underneath, the market rotated rather than sold off: the **Dow rose 1.02 per cent**, the **Nasdaq was flat**, and the dollar eased to **DXY 101.70**.[3][4]

Gold and bitcoin split on the same news. **Gold fell 0.38 per cent to $4,124.10**: the de-escalation headline cut the war premium faster than a softer dollar could replace it, and at a 5.12 per cent ten-year the carrying cost beats the haven bid. **Bitcoin rose 1.10 to $82,825**, trading as a liquidity asset, not a hedge. The regime: **higher-for-longer, with a de-escalating energy premium**. Not advice.[4]

THE LEVELS · TUESDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.79%	▲ 2bp
US 10-year[2]	5.12%	▼ 3bp

One service put DXY at **101.53** in its wrap against **101.70** on its quote page; the quote page is printed. Not advice.[4]

THE CHATTER · A BUY SIGNAL, AND BURNOUT

Ohsung Kwon of Wells Fargo: his sentiment indicator hit **−1.0** on 20 October, a **Buy signal, the first since June 2025** — historically the S&P 500 rose **89 per cent** of the time afterwards, averaging **+6.5** over three months. His own caveat: **"sentiment may have gotten too bearish around AI financing, midterms, and Iran"**. Against him, **Nicholas Colas** of DataTrek: **"equity investors are not used to being venture investors"**.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE BOND MARKET MAY HAVE HIKED ALREADY

One research note argues the causality runs the other way: the ten-year has held above **5 per cent** for three weeks, so the bond market has already delivered the tightening — the September hike to **3.75–4.00** came *after* long rates rose to match it. Its decomposition is the useful part: the ten-year ran **4.19 to 5.22 per cent** this year, of which real yield did **1.94 to 2.87** and term premium **0.58 to 1.08**, while breakevens moved only **2.25 to 2.35**. **It flagged two kill switches — a hot September CPI and Brent above $100 — and both have since fired.**[6]

SOURCES 1 A commodities wire, read at source, for the Qatar–Pakistan report, the US$6bn figure, the 2.3 per cent intraday fall to $106.99 and the settle near $108.92; oilprice.com's front page for Brent at $109.10 on 21 October. **The plan itself is unconfirmed and is printed as a report, not a fact.** 2 **The US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file for October 2026, read row by row at source**, for the 2-, 5-, 10- and 30-year yields on 19 and 20 October; the 2s10s spread and the figure above are this desk's arithmetic on those rows. 3 A US retail bank's rate commentary of 14 October and a market data service, both read at source, for September CPI at 3.7 per cent, the 3.75–4.00 target range, the 15–16 September hike and the blackout dates; the FedWatch probabilities as carried on 20 October. 4 **Levels read at source instrument by instrument**: VWRA, AGGU, BNDW and the STI on a market data service; DXY, USD/SGD and USD/JPY on a quote service; gold on a bullion service at 17:00 EST on 20 October; bitcoin on a crypto data service; US equity closes from a markets wire. 5 A markets wire, 20 October 2026, read at source, for Mr Kwon's indicator, signal history and quoted lines; the Securities Investors Association (Singapore) wrap for Mr Colas. 6 A research note of 14 October 2026, read at source, for the yield decomposition and the argument. **It is a forward-looking scenario piece carried on an exchange's news page and is labelled as such. CNBC, FXStreet, Advisor Perspectives and ETF Trends all returned 403 to this desk; the exchange's own interface rendered nothing.**

THE INVITATION · AMATEUR MYCOLOGY

Fungi on iNaturalist pass 22.9 million records; Singapore confirms one in ten

Mushroom Observer adds 644,381 more from 91,897 users. In Singapore the confirmation rate is 10.4 per cent — and that gap is the whole invitation.

Four hobbies share one name and barely overlap in equipment: **field identification**, a knife and a book and a loupe; **microscopy**, a desk hobby that is not real below a thousand times with an oil-immersion objective; **home cultivation**, whose true subject is contamination; and the newest layer, **citizen-science sequencing**, where amateurs generate DNA barcodes that land in GenBank. Say which one you mean before spending anything.

The scale is genuinely large and genuinely unfinished. iNaturalist holds **22,926,349** observations of fungi from **1,265,216** distinct observers across **38,053** taxa — and only **27.9 per cent** have reached Research Grade, its term for two independent identifications agreeing. Mushroom Observer, slower and more expert, holds **644,381** observations and **91,897** users. Shroomery, the oldest dedicated forum, has **198,702** members and peaked at **53,265** online on **30 August 2026**.[1][2]

The hook is the thing almost no other hobby still offers: **an amateur can find a species nobody has named**. In the California chapter of the Fungal Diversity Survey's first year, roughly **2,000** collections were sequenced and **17 per cent matched nothing known**. **Harte Singer**, a professional chef turned mycologist who runs a DNA laboratory in his Santa Rosa garage, has sequenced **more than 10,000** fungi and flagged **up to 1,000** as potential new species. **"I was spending all my discretionary income on sequencing mushrooms,"** he told Bay Nature. **Damon Tighe**, in the same piece: **"We pulled so many new species out of the chaparral that it's just jaw-dropping."**[3]

There is money arriving too, though nobody agrees how much. Fortune Business Insights values the functional-mushroom market at **US$33.72bn** in 2025, with Asia Pacific at **51.74 per cent** of it. Grand View Research says **$38.24bn**; Mordor Intelligence says **$12.06bn**. A factor of three, and that is the finding: the category is defined differently by everyone selling research about it.[4]

27.9%

OF 22,926,349 INATURALIST FUNGAL OBSERVATIONS ARE CONFIRMED. IN SINGAPORE: 10.4[1]

THE CHATTER · WHERE EVERYONE ACTUALLY IS

The subreddits, counted on 2 October 2026: **r/mycology 943,000** members, up **10.9 per cent** in a year and overwhelmingly "ID request"; **r/foraging 800,000**; **r/MushroomGrowers 375,000**, with a dedicated **Contamination** flair; **r/ShroomID 262,000**, whose flair list includes **"Emergency"** — a poisoning triage channel. On YouTube the authority is **Learn Your Land** (Adam Haritan), **601,000** subscribers and **46.6 million** views across 242 videos; then **FreshCap** at 496,000 and the retailer **North Spore** at 327,000.[5][6]

THE SCEPTIC · THE RECORD IS THINNER THAN THE NUMBERS LOOK

Seventy-two per cent of the world's largest fungal dataset is unconfirmed, and the people inside it are blunt about why. In an iNaturalist forum thread opened on **23 August 2025** and still running, the member **kallampero** estimates that **"upwards of 90% of all of iNat's fungal observations"** are wrong, and blames the computer-vision suggestions for optimising **"user satisfaction at the expense of database integrity"**. Another, **catsear**: **"It once suggested to me that a photograph of mold on a cantaloupe was an earth star."** The 90 per cent is one member's estimate, not a measurement — but 27.9 per cent is the platform's own arithmetic.[7]

What follows goes into the three places the money and the argument live: the factions, the gear from a US$38 knife to a US$6,200 sequencing bench, and what this hobby can and cannot be in Singapore.

SOURCES 1 **iNaturalist's own public API, queried directly on 20 October 2026**, for the total, research-grade, observer and taxon counts, and for the Singapore place figures (11,073 observations, 576 species-level taxa, 1,575 observers, 1,154 research grade). **iNaturalist's web pages return 403 to this desk; the API does not.** 2 **Mushroom Observer's own API, queried directly**, for its three counts; Shroomery's own forum index, read at source, for membership and the 30 August 2026 peak. 3 Bay Nature, "People Are Sequencing Mushroom DNA at Home Now," Tanvi Dutta Gupta, 30 September 2026, read at source, for Mr Singer, the quoted remarks, the 17 per cent and the 10,000 and 1,000 figures. 4 Fortune Business Insights' functional-mushrooms report page, last updated 5 October 2026, read at source; the Grand View and Mordor figures are from search summaries and are given only to show the spread. 5 Subreddit membership and growth from a public subreddit-analytics service whose page states its data was last updated 2 October 2026. **Reddit itself refused this desk for a seventh consecutive issue, by every route tried.** 6 YouTube channel About pages, read at source on 20 October 2026. 7 The iNaturalist community forum thread "AI Suggestions in Fungal Observations," opened 23 August 2025, read at source and quoted under the handles posted.

THE DEEP END · THE GEAR

Stephen Russell prices a home nanopore bench at US$5,700; MycoMap sequences free

Stephen Russell's published nanopore protocol puts the bench at US$5,700–6,200 upfront. MycoMap now does it free, and that changes the whole ladder.

Start at the cheap end. The field knife is not in dispute: the **Opinel No. 8 mushroom knife** is **US$40** at Opinel's own US store and **US$38** at North Spore — the mushroom shop undercuts the maker. Add a regional guide, a burlap bag at **US$11.99**, and a ten-times triplet loupe — **whose price this desk could not verify**, because the two makers the community names do not resolve and both marketplaces refused.[1]

Microscopy is where the first real money goes, and the bar is specific: **1,000× with a true 100× oil-immersion objective and a condenser you can oil**. The new-Chinese workhorse band runs **US$1,017 to US$1,311** — AmScope's T660, T690, T670 — and the buy-once alternative is a **refurbished Olympus BH-2 at about US$1,945**, a stand that outlives its owner. Two traps: **"1500X"** on a box means nothing without the objective set, which AmScope's own page does not list; and eBay BH2 units at **US$7,250–7,950** are Nomarski metallurgical rigs.[2]

Cultivation's buy-once item is the pressure steriliser, and **All American** is the only brand serious growers name. The **1925X** is **US$699.95** at one shop and **US$699.99** at another — four cents apart, which is the real street price. The honest beginner answer is below all of it: a **Presto 01781, 23 quart, US$184.99**. Sterile air divides into a church and a chapel — a flow hood from **US$339.99** to **US$1,849**, or a **still-air box at US$74.99** and patience.[3]

Then the layer that did not exist five years ago. **Stephen Russell**'s nanopore barcoding protocol, published with his own itemised prices, puts the bench at **US$5,700–6,200** all-in before a thermocycler — a Flongle pack at **$1,460**, a MinION at **$1,000**, a freezer off Facebook Marketplace for **$150** ("gotta get lucky"). Running cost: **53 cents a specimen**. Against all of it, **MycoMap says sequencing is free, for an unlimited number of specimens**, with results published as DNA-validated records.[4][5]

THE FACTIONS, AND WHAT THEY ARE ARGUING ABOUT

Trusted Cultivators against everyone else. Shroomery enshrines a formal hierarchy in a thread title: **"Only TCs Can Answer!"** Its cultivation board holds **4,327,450** posts against **234,811** on the gourmet board — one technique, two legal universes, one forum.[6]

THE CHATTER · THE BEGINNER MISTAKES, IN THE COMMUNITY'S OWN WORDS

Drawn from the forums, not invented: **"You will not do grains successfully with spore syringes." "Easiest is never the most productive. You need to choose between them." "If you don't have a pressure cooker, get one."** Do not silicone the HEPA filter in; it is a consumable. And do not push a photo-only observation to species because Research Grade feels like a score.[7]

THE SCEPTIC · THE BENCH THAT PAYS BACK AT ELEVEN THOUSAND SPECIMENS

Do the division. **US$5,700 upfront to reach 53 cents a specimen** means roughly **11,000** specimens before you break even against a free MycoMap network slot, or about **200** against a thirty-dollar Sanger service. For almost every hobbyist the right answer is to post the sample. Meanwhile the supply side has wobbled: every premium flow hood at one major retailer is sold out, five of six All American units at another, and North Spore has dropped flow hoods from its catalogue entirely. **Buy the steriliser when you see one in stock.**[3][4]

SOURCES 1 **Opinel's own US store and North Spore's own product feed, both read at source**, for the knife prices and the burlap bag. **The two loupe makers the community names do not resolve from this sandbox and both marketplaces returned 503 or 403, so no loupe price is printed.** 2 **AmScope's own product catalogue, read at source on 20 October 2026**, for the T660, T670 and T690 bands and for the T800 page that advertises magnification without listing objectives; refurbished Olympus BH-2 pricing from dealer listings, single-sourced and flagged as such, with eBay refusing this desk. 3 **Shroom Supply's, North Spore's and Out-Grow's own catalogues, all read the same day**, for every All American price and the three-way spread; Midwest Grow Kits for the Presto; North Spore for the NocBox; Bonsai's own listings for the hood ladder and the replacement-filter prices. 4 **Stephen Douglas Russell, "ONT DNA Barcoding Fungal Amplicons w/ MinION & Flongle," protocols.io v3, DOI 10.17504/protocols.io.36wgq7qykvk5/v3, read at source**, for every itemised price and every per-specimen figure; **Oxford Nanopore's own product page, read at source**, for the Mk1D pack. **Flongle list prices could not be read; those pages 404.** 5 **MycoMap's own site, read at source**, for the free-sequencing claim, the Mycota Lab arrangement and the FungAI and MycoMap Vision tools; **FunDiS' own DNA Sequence Validation Corps page, read at source**, for the workshop and 100-per-cent assessment requirement. 6 **NAMA's own vouchering page, read at source.** 7 Shroomery's own board pages and thread titles, read at source, with post counts as its index reports them.

THE DEEP END · THE NINETY DAYS

Picture Mushroom identified the death cap correctly three times in five

The only independent test, in Clinical Toxicology in 2023, put three apps at 35 to 49 per cent overall. French poison centres logged 30 app-involved cases in half of 2022, against six in all of 2021.

The sceptic's case begins with the one rigorous study. Hodgson, McKenzie, May and Greene tested three apps against **78** specimens sent to the Victorian Poisons Information Centre, each confirmed by an expert mycologist, in *Clinical Toxicology*, **March 2023**. Overall accuracy: **Picture Mushroom 49 per cent, Mushroom Identificator 35, iNaturalist 35**; on poisonous species, **44, 30 and 40**. On *Amanita phalloides*, the death cap: **Mushroom Identificator 67, Picture Mushroom 60, iNaturalist 27** — and Picture Mushroom called it something else twice. The apps, they conclude, cannot rule out exposure when used alone.[1]

Set that beside the claim. A presentation to European regulators in **Brussels on 8 November 2023** noted that **"the accuracy rate declared by developers is 80-90%"**, and cited the French agency: of **1,923** poisoning cases logged in the second half of **2022**, **30 involved identification apps, against six in all of 2021**. The community is blunter: **"They are all unreliable."**[2]

The second money pit is the supplement shelf, and the mechanism is a labelling trick. The supplier Nammex tested roughly **100** samples: whole dried mushrooms ran **6.79 to 49.3 per cent** beta-glucan against **0.1 to 1.65** starch, while mycelium grown on grain ran **1.06 to 15.26** against **24.55 to 66.4**. Whole reishi: **28.1 per cent** beta-glucan against **0.1** starch; reishi mycelium, **1.06** against **51.44**. Labels quote **"total polysaccharide"**, which counts starch too: a jar that is **45 per cent rice flour** advertises a fine number. **Nammex sells fruiting-body extracts and has a direct interest in the finding.**[3]

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE, WHERE THE RECORD IS THE OPPORTUNITY

Foraging here is close to a non-starter: no temperate autumn, so no season to build a club calendar around; the forest is nature reserve, so collecting is effectively closed; and Lee and Choong's *A Guide to Macrofungi in Singapore* (2023) covers about **160** species where a revised Carolinas guide covers a thousand. But the Botanic Gardens are running **"Funtastical World of Fungi" at the CDL Green Gallery until 28 February 2027**, showing an *Amanita sculpta* with a **26cm** cap — first recorded here in **1940** and unseen for eighty years until 2020.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · NINE IN TEN SINGAPORE RECORDS ARE UNCONFIRMED

iNaturalist holds **11,073** fungal observations from Singapore across **576** species-level taxa — and only **1,154**, **10.4 per cent**, are Research Grade, against 27.9 globally. Nine in ten cannot be confirmed by anyone. Read one way that is an indictment; read the other, it is the case for the hobby here. What works in this climate is **indoor cultivation of tropical gourmet species** — and a record thin enough that a careful amateur is not at the edge of a saturated field. The researchers' own standing line, from a 2023 Singapore record: **"the authors strongly advise against the consumption of wild mushrooms."**[5]

NEXT DESCENTS

Violin making — a three-hundred-year varnish argument, and a blind test nobody wanted.

Sheepdog trialling — a century of bloodline politics and five-figure dogs at Skipton.

Retrocomputing restoration — recapping dead machines, and the chips nobody makes any more.

SOURCES 1 Hodgson SE, McKenzie C, May TW, Greene SL, "A comparison of the accuracy of mushroom identification applications using digital photographs," *Clinical Toxicology* 2023;61(3):166–172, doi:10.1080/15563650.2022.2162917 — **abstract read in full at source through the National Library of Medicine's own interface**, for every accuracy figure and the authors' conclusion. 2 **A presentation to the European Food Safety Authority's stakeholder discussion group, Brussels, 8 November 2023, downloaded as a PDF and text-extracted**, for the developers' 80–90 per cent claim and for the French figures it cites from the national agency's July 2023 report. 3 **Nammex's own published testing, read at source**, for every beta-glucan and starch figure and for the total-polysaccharide mechanism. **Nammex is a commercial supplier of fruiting-body extracts; the conflict is stated here rather than buried.** 4 Prices as sourced on p16, plus Cosori's and Excalibur's own catalogues, NAMA's own dues page and Atom Scientific's Melzer's listing (product RRSP48, £16.16 for 100ml), all read at source. **The US scheduling claim circulating for chloral hydrate could not be confirmed at a primary source and is not asserted here.** 5 The Singapore Art Museum's own event page for "All About Mycology" (16 February 2022), read at source, for the group, its founder and its growth; a Singapore family-activities title, read at source, for the Botanic Gardens exhibition, its dates and the *Amanita sculpta* specimen. **iNaturalist's own API, queried for place 6734 on 20 October 2026**, for all five Singapore figures; Tan, Lee & Low 2023, *Nature in Singapore* 16: e2023071, read at source, for the quoted advice.

FITNESS · THE ATTICA COHORT

The ATTICA cohort ties half of later frailty to midlife inactivity

The Greek cohort, published 19 October, puts the population attributable fraction at 49.5 per cent. People who took up exercise did almost as well as those who never stopped.

The *Journal of Frailty & Aging* published the **ATTICA** cohort's twenty-two-year read on **Monday 19 October**. Participants were recruited in **2002**, all older than **33**, and classified at baseline, five years and ten years against **600 MET-minutes a week** into four trajectories. Outcome measured in **2024**. Against persistent inactivity, the persistently active had about **80 per cent** lower odds of pre-frailty or frailty — and the **inclining** group, who started late, had about **79**.[1]

One percentage point is what starting late cost, and that is the finding worth carrying out of the paper. The authors put the **population attributable fraction** for unhealthy midlife activity trajectories at **49.5 per cent** (95% CI 36.3 to 59.9), rising to **64.8** (CI 49.6 to 75.4) once hypertension, diabetes, high cholesterol and obesity are folded in. The exposure window — measured at 33, again at 38, again at 43 — is precisely the decade a mid-forties reader is finishing.[1]

Two honest gaps sit in that abstract. **It does not state a sample size**, and it gives the headline results as "80 per cent" and "79 per cent" decreased odds **with no odds ratios and no confidence intervals**. The attributable fraction has its interval and is printed with it; the 80 and 79 are the authors' own wording, bare.[1]

49.5%

OF PRE-FRAILTY AND FRAILTY AT 22 YEARS ATTRIBUTED TO MIDLIFE INACTIVITY (CI 36.3–59.9)[1]

ALSO IN THE LITERATURE

Fitness at eighteen, mood at sixty-one. Stenling and colleagues in the *Journal of Aging and Health*, 19 October: **690** Swedish men fitness-tested at **18** and assessed for depressive symptoms at about **61**. Against low fitness, medium fitness gave an odds ratio of **0.329** (CI 0.157–0.687) and high fitness **0.383** (CI 0.157–0.939). Later physical activity showed **no credible mediating effect** — the association did not run through staying active. Men only, single-sourced.[2]

Exercise as oncology, with the caveat attached. A review in *Cancer Treatment Reviews* on 13 October: pooled analyses across more than **1.4 million** people link activity to lower incidence of at least **13** tumour types, with cancer-specific mortality **24 to 31 per cent** lower among the most active patients. It states plainly that those estimates **rely on self-reported activity**, and pairs one positive phase III trial with a randomised ovarian trial showing **no** benefit.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE DRUG THAT KEEPS THE MASS AND NOT THE STRENGTH

Peter Attia's team on the EMBRAZE trial, 3 October: **102** adults on apitegromab or placebo alongside tirzepatide for 24 weeks. Both arms lost about **12kg**. On drug, lean mass was **14.6 per cent** of the loss; on placebo, **30.2**. But function did not follow — grip strength **+0.9kg against −0.3kg**, p about **0.72**. Attia: **"they don't deliver what's most important about muscle: Strength"**.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE ONE RANDOMISED TRIAL PUBLISHED THE SAME DAY

PROACTIVE-19, in *GeroScience* on **19 October** — the same day as ATTICA — randomised Hungarian adults over **60** to general or personalised telephone lifestyle counselling, **441** analysed. Mortality did not differ: **HR 0.66, 95% CI 0.28 to 1.53**, an interval that crosses one. And in the arm that tried hardest, **BMI rose** among participants with obesity (β 0.068, CI 0.013–0.119). ATTICA's headline is an attributable fraction, which means what it says only if the association is causal, and its exposure is self-reported. **No named researcher has criticised the ATTICA paper — it is two days old, and this desk will not invent dissent that does not exist.**[5]

General guidance, not medical advice. The actionable sentence in all of it is the one-point gap between 79 and 80.

SOURCES 1 Sgouropoulou D, Giannakopoulou SP, Damigou E and colleagues, "Midlife physical activity trajectories are associated with reduced physical pre-frailty/frailty in older age: insights from the prospective ATTICA sub-study 2002–2024," *Journal of Frailty & Aging*, online 19 October 2026, 15(6):100217 — **abstract read in full at source through the National Library of Medicine's own interface**, for the design, the 600 MET-minute threshold, the four trajectories, the 80 and 79 per cent figures and both attributable fractions with their intervals. **The abstract states no sample size and no odds ratios; neither is supplied here.** 2 Stenling A, Praetorius Björk M, Ekblom-Bak E and colleagues, "Cardiorespiratory Fitness in Young Adulthood and Depressive Symptoms Later in Life Among Swedish Men," *Journal of Aging and Health*, online 19 October 2026 — abstract read at source through the same interface. 3 Schmidinger M, Huebner-Resch I and Shariat SF, "Exercise as anticancer medicine? Evidence, mechanisms and implementation in oncology," *Cancer Treatment Reviews*, 13 October 2026, 151:103222 — abstract read at source, including its own self-report caveat and the contrasting trial results. 4 Peter Attia's own site, 3 October 2026, read at source, reporting Pratley RE and colleagues in *Nature Medicine* 2026;32(7):2673–2678, for every EMBRAZE figure and quotation. 5 Váncsa S, Nagy-Szakolczai A, Molontay R and colleagues for the PROACTIVE-19 contributors, *GeroScience*, online 19 October 2026, NCT04321928 — abstract read at source. **Hacker News carried nothing on frailty or exercise-longevity in the window and Sweat Science has published nothing on the subject since 7 October; no dissent is attributed to anyone who has not offered it.**

THE DIARY · BOOKING THIS WEEK

Tokyo's Louvre show stops admitting ordinary tickets after 6 December

Timed tickets for 7–13 December go on sale at noon on Friday 31 October. The Kyushu sumo basho is sold out on all fifteen days.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

29 Oct–22 Nov ★ **CATS the Musical**
SANDS THEATRE · **FROM S$68**, VIP TO S$238 · RATED G · **DYNAMIC PRICING: THE FLOOR RISES AS THE HOUSE FILLS**

29 OCT **Tampines Rovers v Svay Rieng, AFC Champions League Two**
JALAN BESAR STADIUM, 6PM · **S$20**, CONCESSION **S$10**

10 & 11 Nov **My Chemical Romance**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · S$148–408 · **APRIL TICKETS AUTO-TRANSFERRED AND STILL VALID**; A SECOND NIGHT ADDED ON DEMAND

12 Nov–27 Dec **Monkey Goes West**
WILD RICE AT FUNAN · PREVIEWS **FROM S$50**, RUNS S$55–120

22 NOV ★ **Simple Plan**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM, 8PM · S$98–148 · **ONE NIGHT, SIX PER TRANSACTION**

28 & 29 Nov ★ **SJ60 Musubi Singapore–Japan Festival**
MARINA BAY SANDS EXPO, 10AM–8PM · **ADULT S$8, CHILD S$4**; TWO-DAY S$12 AND S$6 · UNDER-4S FREE

25–29 Nov **The Nutcracker, State Ballet of Georgia**
SANDS THEATRE · S$48–208 · **FAMILY SAVER: FOUR A RESERVE S$500, FOUR C RESERVE S$280**, ANY NIGHT BUT SATURDAY

26–29 Nov **Affordable Art Fair**
F1 PIT BUILDING · **THREE-DAY S$24 TO 22 NOV, THEN S$28** · UNDER-16S FREE

28 NOV **NieR:Orchestra Concert 12026 [YoRHa]**
THE STAR THEATRE, 7.30PM · S$68–298 · **RATED GENERAL, ADMITS FROM 3**

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

to 13 Dec ★ **Renaissance Masterpieces from the Louvre**
NATIONAL ART CENTER, TOKYO · ¥2,400 GENERAL · **ORDINARY TICKETS ADMIT ONLY TO 6 DEC; 7–13 DEC NEEDS A TIMED TICKET, ON SALE NOON 31 OCT** · 15 AND UNDER FREE

31 Oct–28 Mar ★ **Mariko Mori · All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM, ROPPONGI · ¥2,600–2,800 · **ADVANCE DISCOUNT ENDS FRI 30 OCT** · JUNIOR-HIGH AND UNDER FREE

28 Oct–8 Feb **Shojo Manga Infinity · Hagio, Yamagishi, Yamato**
NATIONAL ART CENTER, TOKYO · **¥2,200 — ONLINE ADVANCE CLOSED 27 OCT** · TWO TERMS, WORKS ROTATED · CHILDREN FREE

7 NOV **Pretty Guardian Sailor Moon · Shining Theater**
SHINAGAWA PRINCE HOTEL CLUB EX · ¥8,000–18,000; **¥4,000 FOR AGES 4–12** · BOOKABLE FROM SINGAPORE

8–22 Nov **Kyushu Grand Sumo Tournament**
FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · **SOLD OUT ON ALL FIFTEEN DAYS**, ON THE ASSOCIATION'S OWN NOTICE

5 DEC ★ **Hatsu basho tickets open**
TOKYO, **10–24 JAN 2027**, RYOGOKU KOKUGIKAN · **SET AN ALARM: KYUSHU SOLD OUT ENTIRELY**

mid-Nov–early Dec **Autumn foliage peak, Kyoto and Tokyo**
NOT TICKETED · **TATEYAMA KUROBE ALREADY PAST PEAK ON 13 OCT**

24 Feb–3 Apr **Cirque du Soleil KOOZA, Tokyo**
ODAIBA BIG TOP · ¥8,800–16,800 · **THE CHILD RATE STOPS AT THE END OF ELEMENTARY SCHOOL**

PLANNING NOTES · AND WHAT THIS DESK DROPPED

Three dates need action before November. Mori Art Museum's advance discount ends **30 October**; the Louvre show's final-week timed tickets go on sale at **noon on 31 October**, and nothing else admits you after 6 December; and **Hatsu basho tickets open on 5 December**, Kyushu having sold out on all fifteen days. **Three Tokyo exhibitions are free for junior-high and under.** *Attack on Titan — Symphony from Paradis* is still on sale and still **NC16**, so a twelve-year-old cannot go. **Dropped for want of a primary:** Kenshi Yonezu's 22 October on-sale — SISTIC's whole 338-event catalogue carries no listing and Ticketmaster Singapore returned 403 — plus BTS, LANY, Joji, both Tokyo illuminations and the Australian Open. **Pulled:** the Dee Dee Bridgewater duo of 29 October, now titled **cancelled** in SISTIC's catalogue.

SOURCES 1 **Every Singapore row was verified today against SISTIC's own ticketing records** — the catalogue and event-detail endpoints its public site calls — for the dates, venue, on-sale date, price tiers, admission rules and, in each case, its own sold-out and availability flags. The human-facing pages are at sistic.com.sg. **Ticketmaster Singapore returned 403 to this desk by every route, which is why no Live Nation show appears above.** 2 **The Mori Art Museum's, the National Art Center's and the Tokyo Photographic Art Museum's own English exhibition pages, all read at source**, for dates, prices, the advance-discount deadlines, the free-for-children rules and the Louvre show's split ticketing. 3 **The Japan Sumo Association's own site, read at source**, for the sold-out notice on the November tournament and the 5 December on-sale for January. 4 The Sailor Moon and KOOZA rows are AXS Japan inventory sold through SISTIC and were read in the same records. 5 Japan-Guide's 2026 foliage reports, read at source, for the Kyoto and Tokyo windows and the Tateyama Kurobe observation of 13 October. 6 The Singapore Writers Festival's own pages, read at source, confirm the early-bird has reverted: the festival pass is now **S$30** regular and the youth pass **S$15**.

THE TABLE · ORCHARD TO YISHUN

Spicy Wife opens an air-conditioned second shop, Spicy Hubby, on Orchard Road

The Amoy Street stall's first mall outlet has 60 seats and runs to 9pm. Every positive account so far is a hosted tasting or a review filed within 48 hours of opening.

Spicy Hubby, which this desk logged at its opening in No. 132, has now been open long enough to be judged — the first mall spin-off of **Spicy Wife Nasi Lemak**, the Amoy Street stall that has drawn a lunch queue since 2022, at The Centrepoint on Orchard Road. It is the fix for the parent: **60 air-conditioned seats**, open **to 9pm**, where Spicy Wife shuts after lunch. The signature **Nasi Goreng Ayam Berempah** is **S$9.90**, its chicken marinated overnight in an eight-ingredient rempah; **Nasi Ayam Gepuk** at **S$12.90** is exclusive here. It is **not halal-certified, but uses no pork and no lard.**[1]

The buzz is warm and thin, and the two should not be confused. MiddleClass filed the only dish-by-dish review, on 16 October, and liked everything — the Ayam Gepuk its favourite: **"If you get one dish, make it this one."** But HungryGoWhere states plainly that its piece came from a **hosted tasting**, and all three visits happened inside three days of opening. **Nobody has paid their own money and gone back.**[1][2]

Three other rooms, all under-covered. **Bar Middle** at 31 Hongkong Street is a twenty-seat cocktail bar run by **Gavin Teverasan**, previously of 28 Hongkong Street and Nutmeg & Clove: Japanese method — ice warmed with a folding fan, every drink built individually — at a flat **S$25** a cocktail. The must-order is his mother's **three-cup chicken wings at S$12**. Honeycombers' only reservation is that the Bitter Ume **"does lean on the bitter side"**. Message ahead; twenty seats settle it.[3]

Rolls Handroll Izakaya, on Club Street, is a temaki counter whose argument is the weekday lunch: **four handrolls S$28, six S$38**, against à-la-carte rolls at S$7.80 to S$13.80. It has **no Chope rating and no reviews at all** — so the defensible claim is that a S$28 CBD lunch set is unusual, not that the fish is good. **Faber Side Cafe & Cellar** at 108 Faber Drive runs Roastworks coffee by day and turns into a wine-and-tapas cellar at night, breakfast from **S$8.90**. Its only signal is three Chope votes — **service 5.0 against food 4.0** — noise, but pointing at a well-run room rather than a kitchen anyone raves about.[4][5]

NASI LEMAK · HANDROLL · TOO NEW TO CALL

THE CHATTER · A QUIET MONTH, AND THE NUMBERS SAY SO

The October bar cohort in Singapore runs to **two** venues, one of which this desk could not substantiate at all. On Chope, read today: **Bar Middle 5.0 from exactly one review**; **Faber Side 4.6 from three**; **Rolls, no rating and no reviews**. There is **no Michelin Guide Singapore addition in October** either. Printing the counts is more honest than rounding them into a consensus that does not exist.[3][4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE PARENT STALL WAS MARKED DOWN ON THE RICE

Nothing negative about Spicy Hubby exists in print, which is a problem of age rather than a verdict. The dissent on the record is against the stall whose reputation it trades on: **Eatbook scored Spicy Wife 8 out of 10**, with stated cons of **"rice was not very flavourful"** and **"chicken was not thoroughly marinated"**, the sambal **"too sweet for my liking"**. Note the rhyme: two outlets at the new shop independently report the sambal leaning **sweet rather than hot**. Go for the chicken; reserve judgement on the rice.[6]

SOURCES 1 HungryGoWhere, 14 October 2026, and Eatbook, 15 October 2026, both read at source, for the address, the opening, the parent stall's 2022 start, the eight-ingredient rempah, the exclusive dishes, the seat count, the hours, the prices and the halal position; **HungryGoWhere states on its own page that the visit was a hosted tasting**. 2 MiddleClass, 16 October 2026, read at source, for every quoted line and for its own observation that the sambal and rendang lean sweet. **This venue could not be confirmed at a primary: its Instagram and the parent's both returned 429 to this desk, it is not listed on Chope, and the mall's own directory is behind a gated servlet. It is printed on three independent first-hand visits dated 14, 15 and 16 October, two of them photographed in the restaurant, plus a dated venue-specific promotion — and the gap is disclosed here rather than hidden.** 3 **Chope's live operator-maintained listing, read at source**, for Bar Middle's address, cuisine, seat count, hours and rating count; Honeycombers' review for the bartender's background, the drinks, the wings and the quoted reservation. 4 **Chope's live listing, read at source**, for Rolls Handroll Izakaya; HungryGoWhere, 14 October 2026, for the lunch sets and prices. 5 **Chope's live listing, read at source**, for Faber Side — address, hours, the 90-minute weekend rule and the 4.6 from three reviews broken out as food 4.0, service 5.0, atmosphere 4.0; TheSmartLocal's 6 October listing for the opening. 6 Eatbook's own review of the parent stall, read at source, for the 8-out-of-10 score and every quoted criticism. **Reddit refused this desk for a seventh consecutive issue; Burpple, Time Out Singapore and both Singapore broadsheets also refused. Every name above was checked against the Table ledger's 83 barred venues and the eleven run in the last fortnight.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · VIETNAM

Hanoi puts Vietnam's new eldercare in offices its own reforms emptied

The first centre opened in Long Biên on 6 June 2026 and six wards now run them. Decree 168/2026 gives the model no legal personality and no central budget line.

The Vietnamese for a crèche is **nhà trẻ** — literally "children's house". The word now circulating for what opened in Long Biên ward in June is **nhà già**: "old-people's house". Nobody in government coined it. On **7 August 2026** the Party daily *Nhân Dân* printed it in a headline, in scare quotes, as **đi "nhà già"**. A state newspaper borrowing a joke it did not make is the surest sign the joke has already landed.[1]

The official name is heavier and more revealing: **điểm chăm sóc người cao tuổi ban ngày**, a community daytime elderly care point, created in law by **Decree 168/2026/NĐ-CP** with effect from **1 July 2026**. The model is also called **dưỡng lão bán trú** — semi-boarding eldercare — and *bán trú* in ordinary Vietnamese is a *schooling* word, for the pupil who comes by day and eats lunch at school. The operating slogan in the official documents is **"sáng đón đi, tối đưa về"**: collected in the morning, brought home in the evening. That is the phrase Vietnamese use for the kindergarten run, and the state has adopted it without irony.[2][3]

What makes this an undercurrent rather than a policy brief is where the buildings came from. On **1 July 2025** Vietnam abolished its district tier and merged its communes and wards — Hanoi's **526** became **126**. The amputation emptied thousands of commune offices and health stations. By **13 July 2026** the Ministry of Finance was counting **more than 11,000** public facilities recovered or transferred and **not yet back in use**. Seven months before that count, on **23 December 2025**, Directive **35/CT-TTg** had already told provinces to take exactly that surplus estate and **"prioritise"** it for elderly day centres.[4][5]

Hanoi moved first. On **6 June 2026** Long Biên ward opened a day centre inside the old **Thạch Bàn** health point, in a ward with more than **8,700** residents over sixty — about **13 per cent** of its people — of whom nearly **6,000** have a chronic condition. Đống Đa followed on 20 July, Việt Hưng on the 28th, then Quốc Oai, Tây Hồ and Bồ Đề. Six wards by **18 September**.[6][7]

The pressure behind it is demographic and close. Vietnam counted **16.5 million** people aged sixty and over in 2025, about **16 per cent** of the population, and is projected to be an aged society by **2036**. Life expectancy is **74.7** years against a healthy **65.4** — nearly a decade in which care is needed. **The official figures do not agree**: other readings give 16.1 million for 2025, and date the aged-society threshold to 2034 or 2038 depending on whether it is measured at sixty or sixty-five.[9]

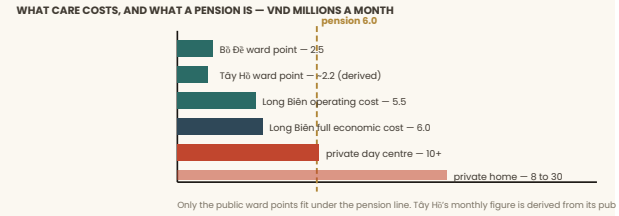
> ***The state once socialised child care to free women for production. It is now socialising elder care for the same reason.***

A day runs from seven in the morning to five in the evening. An arrival check logs blood pressure and blood glucose against a digital health record; diabetics' diets are watched more closely. Then physiotherapy, gentle yoga, balance work, *dưỡng sinh* exercise; herbal foot soaks; afternoon acupressure; chess, singing, reading; lunch. Several centres also teach smartphone use, video-calling and how to spot a scam. Bồ Đề runs **20 beds, five restrooms and seven caregivers**, with a five-day trial rotation and priority to those aged **70 to 75** who can manage basic self-care. Quốc Oai serves about **40** people a day, free, in twelve functional rooms, with no meals and no medical supplies.[7][8]

SOURCES 1 *Nhân Dân*, 7 August 2026, read at source, for the headline use of *nhà già* in scare quotes and for the popular nickname. 2 A provincial daily's report of 22 May 2026, read at source, for Decree 168/2026/NĐ-CP, its 1 July 2026 effect, the absence of legal personality, the bar on examination and treatment, the volunteer staffing and the local-budget funding. **The decree text itself was not read: the Vietnamese legal database returned 403.** 3 *Nhân Dân*, as above, for *dưỡng lão bán trú*; etymologies are standard Vietnamese usage. 4 VietnamNet's English edition, 13 July 2026, read at source, for the Ministry of Finance's count of more than 11,000 recovered facilities. **The ministry's own release was not read.** The 526-to-126 figure is carried by Viet Nam News, 19 September 2026, read at source. 5 VTC News, 24 December 2025, read at source, for Directive 35/CT-TTg, its signature date, the instruction to reallocate surplus premises and the "sáng đón đi, tối đưa về" principle; corroborated on VietnamPlus' English service. 6 *Nhân Dân* and Báo Đầu Tư, both read at source, for the 6 June opening, the Thạch Bàn health point and the ward's elderly population. 7 Dân Trí, 22 September 2026, read at source, for the six wards, their opening dates and the uptake figures on p22. 8 VnExpress International and Viet Nam News, both read at source, for the daily programme, the Bồ Đề and Quốc Oai detail. 9 VnExpress, 10 October 2026, read at source, for the 16.5 million, the 2036 projection, the 2050 share and both life-expectancy figures; **the competing counts are from the health ministry's draft decree via a regional wire, the statistics office, and a 2025 statistics-office and UNFPA forecast, and are given as a discrepancy rather than reconciled.**

The economics are engineered downward on purpose. Long Biên's full economic cost is about **250,000 dong a person a day** — roughly 50,000 for lunch and snacks and 200,000 for care, consultation, health management and exercise — which annualises to about **six million dong a month**. Tây Hồ charges the family **100,000 dong a day**. Bồ Đề plans to collect **2.5 million a month**. A private day centre in Hanoi charges **more than ten million**, and a private residential home between **eight and thirty**.[1]

Set those against the sum General Secretary **Tô Lâm** used: a pension of **six million dong** against a nursing-home fee of **ten million**. People cannot afford to enter. He named day centres the right direction, said progress was slow, and — the sentence that explains the architecture — argued that elderly care should receive **the same priority as care for schoolchildren**. The kindergarten analogy is not a journalist's conceit. It is the governing instruction.[2]



A Meridian figure. Monthly costs as published by each source; the Tây Hồ bar is this desk's arithmetic on its 100,000-dong daily charge and is labelled as derived.[12]

Decree 168 then nationalised the form, and did it as a deliberately weightless legal object. The day-care point has **no legal personality** and **may not examine or treat patients**. It sits under the commune health station. It is staffed by volunteers serving **"trên tinh thần tự nguyện, không hưởng thù lao"** — voluntarily, unpaid — alongside existing health staff and population collaborators. And it is funded mainly from the **local** budget. Decision **1116/QĐ-TTg** of 22 June set the national target at **20 per cent** of communes and wards by 2030; Hanoi's Plan **332/KH-UBND** went further and requires at least one point in every one of its **126** wards and communes.[34]

Read Decision 1116's targets and the shape of the ambition is clear enough. By **2030**: **90 per cent** of older people managed for non-communicable disease; **90 per cent** of communes with an elderly care club; **20 per cent** running a day-care facility; **100 per cent** of provinces with a geriatric department. Signed on **22 June 2026**, it widened the national programme from *health care* for older people to *care* for them — a change of noun that carries the whole policy.[4]

A state that has learned to produce welfare without producing fiscal commitments.

So the binding constraint is not demand and it is not real estate. It is recurrent money and labour — and that is exactly what the pilot has not solved. Hanoi has set **no fee schedule**; the centres run on community donations and partial state support; Tây Hồ's own officials concede that long-term financial sustainability is a serious challenge. Families in retired-civil-servant neighbourhoods are lobbying for fees pegged to **public preschool tuition** — the kindergarten comparison again, this time coming back up from the households.[5]

There is also a question about how much of this is new. Vietnam already runs **more than 9,000** intergenerational self-help clubs and nearly **80,000** cultural and sports clubs with over **3 million** older members. A target of 90 per cent of communes holding at least one elderly club is, substantially, a target for institutions that already exist — which makes the **20 per cent** day-care figure the only genuinely new building in the decision, and the only one that needs recurrent money.[47]

And the uptake is small. Across the six wards, roughly **2,070 cumulative visits** and about **64 regular registrants** as of **18 September** — Long Biên with more than 600 visits and 20 regulars, Quốc Oai about 700 visits and 8, Đống Đa more than 450 and 16. Hanoi has **1.4 million** residents over sixty, more than **16 per cent** of its population, heading for **1.71 million** by 2030. That is on the order of **one regular place for every 21,000 older Hanoians**.[6]

SOURCES 1 *Nhân Dân*, 23 July 2026, and Viet Nam News, 19 September 2026, both read at source, for Long Biên's 250,000-dong daily cost and its breakdown and for the private-centre comparison; VnExpress International, read at source, for Tây Hồ's 100,000-dong daily charge, Bồ Đề's planned 2.5 million and Long Biên's 5.5 million operating estimate; VnExpress, 31 October 2025, for the 8-to-30 million residential range. 2 Viet Nam News, 14 December 2025, read at source, for Tô Lâm's six-against-ten-million sum and his schoolchildren comparison; corroborated by a Vietnamese business title of 3 October 2025. 3 A provincial daily's report of 22 May 2026, read at source, for Decree 168/2026/NĐ-CP's terms, quoted in the original. 4 TheLEADER, 24 June 2026, read at source, for Decision 1116/QĐ-TTg and the 2030 targets; Dân Trí, 27 August 2026, for Hanoi's Plan 332/KH-UBND and Resolution 80/2026/NQ-HĐND. **None of these statutes was read in its own text: the Vietnamese legal database returned 403.** 5 VnExpress International, read at source, for the absent fee schedule, the donation funding, Tây Hồ's concession and the preschool-tuition comparison. 6 Dân Trí, 22 September 2026, read at source, for the per-ward visit and registrant counts; VnEconomy, 29 July 2026, for Hanoi's 1.4 million over-sixties, the 16 per cent share and the 1.71 million projection. **The one-place-per-21,000 figure is this desk's arithmetic on those two sources and is labelled as such.** 7 VietnamPlus, read at source, for the 9,000 intergenerational clubs, the 80,000 cultural and sports clubs and the 3 million members.

The counter-read has a name and an office. **Matt Jackson**, the UNFPA's representative in Vietnam, calls community-based care promising but **"still at an early stage"**, short of geriatric facilities and trained professionals, and says quality care still depends largely on out-of-pocket spending. His figures sharpen it: about **99 per cent** of older Vietnamese live at home, **90 per cent** need regular care, and roughly **1 per cent** are in any institution. And **72 per cent of unpaid care work in Vietnam is done by women**.[1]

That last number is where the architecture shows its hand. Decree 168 staffs its day-care points with volunteers serving *without remuneration*, alongside population collaborators and village health workers, cadres that are overwhelmingly female. What is presented as the socialisation of care is, in its labour accounting, partly its rostering. **Vũ Thu Hà**, vice-chairwoman of the Hanoi People's Committee, is the official brake on her own programme: the model supports preventive care, she says, but it is a pilot, and results and emerging problems must be assessed before wider rollout.[2]

A volunteer army delivers astonishing coverage cheaply. It is also overwhelmingly female, barely paid, and invisible in the accounts.

Which is why the history rhymes so exactly, and the first precedent is Vietnam's own. Under collectivisation the cooperative did not only farm; it ran the **nhà trẻ**, and the crèche existed to release women into collective production. It came apart when the **1980** switch to subcontracting freed women from cooperative group work and the crèche could no longer match their hours; collective agriculture was abolished by **Resolution 10 of 1988**. The state socialised child care to free women for production, and watched it dissolve the moment the production system that paid for it changed. It is now socialising elder care, for the same reason, out of the same kind of building.[4]

Coverage of the thing that costs money is thin: only about **42 per cent** of older people drew a pension or allowance in 2025, against a **55 per cent** target. Vietnam is proposing a contributory long-term care insurance before it has built a universal pension — the reverse of the Japanese and Korean sequence.[3]

The second precedent is next door. Thailand's health ministry manages about **1.04 million** village health volunteers, a pillar of Thai primary care for four decades on the World Health Organization's account. They are paid **1,000 baht a month** — about **32 US dollars** — and in March 2020 they made **3.3 million** household visits in three weeks, then **8 million** more in the next fortnight. In the village the WHO observed, **120 of 130** were women. Vietnamese officials are studying Thailand explicitly. A volunteer army delivers astonishing coverage cheaply; it is also overwhelmingly female, barely paid, and invisible in the accounts.[5]

So the argument is this. Vietnam has discovered that the cheapest way to build an eldercare state is to put it in the buildings a bureaucratic amputation left behind, and to name it after the kindergarten. That is not an accident; the General Secretary said the quiet part out loud when he asked for the old to be given the same priority as schoolchildren. It reveals a state that has learned to produce welfare without producing fiscal commitments: no legal personality, no paid staff, no central budget line, a national target met out of surplus real estate and volunteer hours. The prediction follows in two parts. The model will spread quickly, because it is almost free to announce. And it will stop at the fee schedule, which Hanoi has still not written. That is what the Prime Minister's plan of **9 October 2026** quietly concedes when it adds a **pilot of long-term care insurance** to the list — the missing financial leg, arriving four months after the first centre opened. Vietnam is about to attempt in its 2030s what Japan attempted from a vastly richer base, with the same architecture and a fraction of the money.[6]

SOURCES 1 TheLEADER, 1 June 2026, read at source, for Matt Jackson's assessment, his quoted characterisation and the 99, 90, 1 and 72 per cent figures. 2 A provincial daily, read at source, for Decree 168's volunteer-staffing language; Dân Trí, 22 September 2026, read at source, for Vũ Thu Hà's remarks. 3 VietnamPlus, read at source, for the 9,000 intergenerational clubs, the 80,000 cultural and sports clubs and the 3 million members; Viet Nam News, 30 September 2026, read at source, for the deputy health minister's 42-against-55 per cent coverage figures; VnExpress, 10 October 2026, for the long-term care insurance pilot. 4 Viet Nam News, 30 September 2026, read at source, for Deputy Health Minister Nguyễn Thị Liên Hương's 42-against-55 per cent coverage figures. 5 A Kyoto University repository study of one northern Vietnamese village, 1958–1998, for the cooperative crèche, the 1980 subcontracting break and the 1988 Resolution 10. **The repository record would not render for this desk, so the author, title and journal could not be recovered; it is a single-village case study and is cited here as such rather than as a national history.** 6 **The World Health Organization's own feature on Thailand's village health volunteers, read at source**, for the 1.04 million, the four decades, the 1,000-baht stipend, both visit counts and the 120-of-130 observation; Sài Gòn Giải Phóng, 16 April 2026, read at source, for Vietnamese officials citing Thailand as the comparator. VnExpress, 10 October 2026, read at source, for the Prime Minister's 9 October plan and the long-term care insurance pilot. **Western coverage check: searches designed to surface Reuters, the BBC, the New York Times, the FT, Bloomberg and Nikkei Asia on this subject returned none of them — the only non-Vietnamese pickup is Asian wire syndication.**

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

Counted, and still counting

No spine today, and no apology for it: some days the news is simply several things at once. The largest of them is a province that answered one question three to one and left nine open. Alberta voted **1,451,579** to **477,642** to stay in Canada — and then endorsed, by margins of 51 to 63 per cent, most of the powers a separation would have handed it (p3). The count is unofficial until the 29th, and the nine questions that will shape the argument were still being tallied as this issue closed.

Elsewhere the week ran on numbers nobody can reconcile. Iran says its mines set three tankers alight south of Hormuz and has named no ship; three services give Gulf oil flows as 8.5, 13.1 and 24 million barrels a day, and each appears in somebody's headline (p4). In Singapore the Senior Minister named **seven** listed companies and promised every lever the state has, twelve years after the Act was written and with no company yet prosecuted (p5).

And two small, exact things worth carrying out of the book. The bar rating on a steam iron is a pump's peak measured against no standard at all, while the machine a tailor buys runs half the number (p6). And of the 22.9 million photographs of fungi on the world's largest nature platform, **27.9 per cent** have been confirmed by a second pair of eyes — in Singapore, one in ten (p15). A record is not the same thing as a reading.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

MERIDIAN · No. 139 · 21 October 2026

SOURCES A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: Elections Alberta's own live results feed, read as JSON because its dashboard renders empty; the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file; Singapore's own environment data feed at two endpoints; the Ministry of Manpower's own releases of 19 and 20 October; Apple's newsroom and Singapore store; Philips' Form 6-K on the SEC's archive and De'Longhi's own 2012 release; the IEC's catalogue entry for IEC 60311:2016; Reliable's, Jiffy's and Laurastar's own product pages; Hugging Face model cards and llama.cpp pull requests; Apple's machine-learning research post; Box Office Mojo and Metacritic; the National Library of Medicine's own interface for every journal abstract; iNaturalist's and Mushroom Observer's own APIs; SISTIC's own ticketing records; and the Mori Art Museum's, the National Art Center's and the Japan Sumo Association's own pages. **Refused this desk:** Reddit, for a seventh consecutive issue; Reuters, the FT, the BBC, the Guardian, the Economist, CNBC, both Singapore broadsheets, CNA, Burpple, Time Out Singapore, The Verge, Digitimes, SCMP, ScienceDirect, the publisher of *Pediatrics*, Ticketmaster Singapore, UKMTO and CENTCOM. **Wikimedia rate-limited its image CDN all session; a different route was used.** Where a figure could not be read at source it is flagged in the page that carries it, or it is not printed. Figures attributed to a commercial party with an interest in them — Nammex on supplement adulteration, vendor-attested benchmark speedups — say so on the page.